

ON THE TRAIL TO FREEDOM

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Ihuoma Iroaganachi

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BY

IHUOMA IROAGANACHI

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DEDICATION

Dedicated to my Father Mmerenwanne Larry Iroaganachi.

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Chapter 1

Agana was running, and the three masked men were pursuing him. They had gleaming long knives in their hands. They were closing in on him, he increased his speed, and he had to escape. He must not be caught by these vicious men who want to kill him for no reason. Agana turned to look; the men were now six in number and were determined to murder him. "Oh my God, where do I run to now?" In the distance, Agana saw a rock with an opening on the side that looked like a cave. "If I run into the cave, they might not find me, and there may be a way of escape there," Agana thought as he sprinted towards the cave. Somewhere in the distance, he heard his father calling. Agana breathed a sigh of relief but kept running. Just as he entered the cave and stared into a long tunnel, he heard his father's voice again.

"Agana."

Agana woke up with a start and realized he had been dreaming. His body was covered with sweat, though the early morning weather was cool. This dream again?

"Agana, are you still sleeping when your age mates are already on the farm?"

Agana quickly got up from his bed. "May the day go well, Nnayi."

His father looked at him without answering.

"Agana, are you alright? What has come over you of late, what is it?"

"Nothing, father, I was having a bad dream."

"A bad dream? Are you feeling sick?"

“No Nnayi, I’m fine.”

Agana walked out of his hut, right behind his father. They could barely see each other in the early morning light. Ekeoma his elder brother was already sharpening his knife on the stone by the side of the Obu. Agana picked up his knife, and hoe and started sharpening his knife vigorously. He noticed from the corner of his eyes that his father was watching him, he increased his speed to convince his father that he was alright.

“It’s enough, boys, let’s go.” Their father called out, walking briskly out of the Obu.

“Ada, be sure to bring our food and water in good time. Don’t be late as you were three days ago when we had to wait hours for you.” Ekeoma said over his shoulder to their younger sister who was fetching the broom to sweep the compound.

“Yes, dede, it won’t happen again.”

“You are always thinking about food, Ekeoma. What would you do in a time of famine if there is one?” Oluoha their father asked him.

“Nnayi food is part of my life. I don’t want to think of famine because there will be none in my lifetime.”

They set out for the farm.

As they walked to the farm, Oluoha observed his two sons as he always did. Agana looked subdued this morning. What could be wrong with him? Agana always made him proud, but lately he has not been himself. What was troubling him, and why wouldn’t he confide in anybody? As he watched his two surviving sons grow into manhood, he felt less and less of the pain and heartbreak he experienced when he lost all his first family to the dreaded chicken pox. Oluoha always remembered the

incident with great sadness because it was his fault. If only he had listened to the advice of his late wives. His love for his younger sister had overridden his good reasoning. Did he think he was superhuman? Oluoha forced his mind back to the present. The past should be where it belongs, the past. The future lies in his two sons, who are alive and well and now trudging ahead of him; if he died now, at least he had people who would continue his lineage, and that knowledge was enough.

Ekeoma, his elder son, took after his mother. He was dark in complexion, above average in height, and stocky. Ekeoma was too easy-going for a man; this bothered his father. Agana, on the other hand, was tall, light-skinned, and handsome, a spitting image of his father in several ways. His slightly crooked nose sat pertly on high cheekbones. His eyes were brown with a liquid glow that lessened the sternness of his looks. He walked with the gait of an athlete. He had tried his hand at wrestling, just like other youngsters in the village, and most of the time he had won. He didn't have to compete with anyone to prove his strength. His fellow youngster in the village has lots of respect for him. They knew he took after his father, a warrior in his days. Everybody in the village knew how Agana's father drove four notorious thieves out of the village and banished them from the village, and none dared return. Agana's father was a Superman in the eyes of every kid and youngster in Amachara village.

As Oluoha, Ekeoma, and Agana made the thirty-minute walk to the farm, each was lost in his own thoughts.

Amachara stood on a hill that covered a wide expanse of land. A river called Obohu separated them from the other surrounding villages. Their farmlands were also across the river. It was believed that the

people of Amachara once lived across the river but migrated to the top of the hill and settled there. They would usually climb down the hill and cross the river to get to the farm.

'Ugba' trees dotted both sides of the track road, and the sound of the Ugba shells cracking pierced the quietness of the morning. Father and sons walked in silence, almost oblivious of the intermittent noise made by the cracking sound of the Ugba.

Ada picked up the broom and bent down to sweep. She started from her father's obu. The obu stood at the entrance of the compound, and a mud wall connected it to the rooms on the right and left of the compound to form a square. Nobody could enter the compound except through the obu. Her mother's room and the room she shared with her younger siblings were on the right, while her stepmother and half-siblings lived in the row of houses on the left. All doors to the rooms opened to the compound. At the corner where the two rows of houses met, a small entrance with a half-wooden door opened to the back entrance of the compound, where the goat and sheep pen were built adjacent to each other. Behind the pen was a yam barn. A little track road behind the barn led further down to the bathroom and toilet, away from the living area.

She swept the compound and all the rooms and packed the debris into a wooden basin and carried it to the banana tree behind her mother's room and poured it on the roots.

Atuma swept out of the kitchen and carried the ashes from the previous night's cooking and dumped it at the banana tree as well. Her morning duty was to warm the food from the night before and leave it for her mother to share for breakfast. Both girls were hurrying to finish

their morning chores so they could start pounding the ingredients their mother would use to cook for their father and brothers, who went to the farm.

Chapter 2

On reaching the farmland, Oluoha pointed out the boundaries of the farmland to them once again. He had been doing that since they were about twelve years old.

“My sons, as I have always said, I want you to take proper note of the ‘oke’ of this farmland because I know that when I’m dead, my kinsmen would want to take my choice farmlands from you because you are still young. You know that they are envious of the fact that I have numerous farmlands, don’t you?”

“We know Father.”

“That is why you need to be very vigilant and wise, Ekeoma, did you hear me?”

“Yes, Nnanyi.”

“The owner of the farmland to the left, next to our own, is Kanu, the son of Ogazi.”

“Chidi’s father.”

“Yes.”

“The owner of this uncultivated farm next to ours on the right is Okafor, the son of Nweke from Umueze, the next village after this farmland. They call him Nwokocha like me.”

“We know him father, we see him and his sons sometimes when we come here to farm or fetch firewood.”

“That’s right. I know you wonder why I repeat these questions. I always remind you so that you will not forget or be confused when the occasion

for defending this farmland arises. I know that it will happen one day. Agana, did you hear me?"

"Yes, Nnanyi."

Agana wondered why his father always directed that question at him after every speech on defending their choice farmlands. He felt his father wanted him to know that someday he would be the one who would shoulder the responsibility of defending the properties when the time came. Though he is the younger of the two sons, his father always depended on him when it came to matters that had to do with intelligence and diligence.

Ekeoma, his elder brother, was aware of this but did not pay any attention to their father's preference for Agana. He seemed to be happy to be ridden of the burden of taking responsibility for the farmland or anything else for that matter. Easy-going, fun-loving, Ekeoma loved to live each day fully without any care.

As they tilled the ground, all around them was quiet except for the sound of their hoe hitting the ground and the occasional chirping of birds in the distance. The early morning sun was up, their perspiring bodies gleamed in the sun. They were stripped to their underwear. They usually did so before starting their work, otherwise the heat would be unbearable.

The farmland was dotted with short, stocky trees that they deliberately left standing while clearing the land. The trees were short with fat trunks and a scattering of branches. The leaves were green, thick, and had the shape of an umbrella. It was told that the last generations before them, people deliberately planted the 'ofeke' trees at strategic points in the farm to provide shade when they needed rest. A

tall person could not stand straight under an ofeke tree. It only provided shade while sitting, and they took shelter under it during rest intervals or while eating.

The cultivation of the farmland was done in three stages. They started by clearing the bush, which lasted for two or three days. They rested for a week to allow the leaves to dry so that when they set them on fire, they would burn easily. After the burning, the women and young girls came and cleared the grounds so the men would be able to till it before the planting took place. During the clearing, the women picked the sizable cut-dried stems and put them in heaps along the boundaries of the farmland. They would later carry them home to be used as firewood. The smaller stems were heaped together and left for the poor people in the community who do not have such farmlands.

Oluoha had many farmlands and usually rotated the cultivation. Whichever farm he chose each year was sure to yield a good harvest, and lots of firewood to boot. This farming season, he chose three of the biggest farmlands, which was a relief to his sons; it was the smallest number in a season they could remember, which meant they would have a lot of time to themselves after the farming period.

As they tilled the ground, Agana remembered the dream again and shuddered. This was the third time he had had this same dream, always in that sequence, and it always ended as he entered the cave. What did it mean? Was it a warning about something, or was his mind playing tricks on him? Could it be the story his father told them and the warnings about the future that were recreating the dream in his subconscious mind? Whom should he confide in? Maybe it was about time he told his father about the dream. He might have an interpretation

or explanation for it, or he might give him a clue to something that would solve the mystery of the dream. He was tired of the dreadful state of mind he always had after the dream. He decided he would tell his father about the dream when they got home, late evening, after dinner would be the best time.

Today, the sky was bright with a tinge of grey, which was an indication that it might rain later in the day. It was the beginning of the farming season, which was usually ushered in by the early rains. Agana thought how soothing it would be if there were a slight drizzle to reduce the heat. But it would slow down their work and affect their father's ailing health. At the thought of their father, Agana looked behind and saw him resting under the shade of an ofeke tree. He realized that as each day passed, their father worked for shorter periods. They had tried several times to dissuade him from coming to the farm with them, but he would not listen. He was old, and his health was failing.

The sound of chattering voices broke into his thoughts. It was the voice of his sisters, Adanna and Atuma

"Is it not too early for food?"

"Nnayi, dede Ekeoma said we should not stay long bringing the food," answered Atuma.

"But that doesn't mean it is mealtime," Adanna chipped in. "We came early so we can get some firewood before the weather gets too hot."

"You did well, my children."

Onuoha watched his two eldest daughters as they picked their way into the farm. They were both beautiful. Adanna, whom he fondly called Ada, was tall and light-skinned like him. She had a sharp tongue and a good sense of humour, while Atuma was quiet, of average height, kind,

and intelligent. With the combination of Agana and Ada, he knew his children would have an edge over the wives of his kinsmen. He felt sad that he would not be alive to see them marry and have children. He only hoped they would choose responsible and hard-working young men who would help them fight when the time came.

What was wrong with him today anyway, he wondered. Why was the thought of death always with him these days? It was a common belief that old people had foreknowledge of their death. Was this how they knew? By constantly thinking of death? He decided he would call a family meeting soon and relay the family history to his children once more and give them some advice, maybe for the last time. Oluoha smiled to himself, he was ready to die; after all, he had lived a good life.

“Nnanyi, why are you smiling?”

“Oh, I’m just admiring my two beautiful daughters. You girls should choose strong, hardworking men for husbands, do you hear me”? I don’t want lazy sons-in-law, and you should also work hard to support your husbands; lazy wives are no good either.”

Ada laughed gaily while Atuma looked down, smiling.

“You’ve told us that severally, Nnanyi, we will not disappoint you,”

Ada answered for the two of them.

“I’m glad to hear that.”

Agana and Ekeoma heard the last bit of the exchange as they walked towards the shade to drink water and eat breakfast.

“What is this talk about men and marriage? Are we going to have suitors knocking at our doors anytime soon? I hope there won’t be a hunch back among them.”

Ada and Atuma burst out laughing.

“No, dede, you can be sure of that.”

A few weeks before, a hunchback from a nearby village had stopped Ada to chat her up by the wayside while she was returning from an errand, Agana saw the man talking to her and has not stopped teasing her about it at every given opportunity.

As soon as the men were seated, Ada brought the food basket and shared the food. There were two pots in the basket, a big one and a smaller one. She kept the food in the bigger pot aside. That will be for lunch. The meal she shared was small in quantity so that the men would not tire easily since it was only mid-morning. By the time they ate their second meal in the late afternoon, they would rest for a longer period and work a little more before heading home. They settled down to eat breakfast.

The meal consisted of ukwa cooked with fresh palm oil and dried fish, and vegetables. It was a tasty light meal. Oluoha’s two wives were good cooks. They were both from a nearby village called Uga. Women from Uga were known to be good cooks, and men from Amachara and its environs scrambled to have them for wives. It was said that you only need to taste the soup prepared by an Uga woman to know who cooked it.

As the men ate their food in silence, the girls went about tying up two bundles of cut, dried stems they would carry home. They kept at it and waited for the men to finish their meal so they could take the empty dishes with them. As soon as they finished eating and drinking, Agana called out to his sisters.

“Do you need help with the ‘Nku’?”

“Yes, dede, we do.”

“Ada, you help Atuma, then I will help you.”

“No dede”, Atuma protested “my ‘aju’ will fall off if Ada helps me, it happens all the time.”

“I wasn’t going to offer to do that anyway,” Ada interjected. “You always stand like a statue every time I want to put the load on your head.”

“Alright, alright, I will help both the statue and the reed.”

Agana got up and helped his sisters put the firewood bundles on their heads. He handed Atuma the bag of empty dishes and waved them off.

“Nnayi, we are leaving,” both said in unison.

“Alright, my children, be careful going home.”

“Yes Nnayi.”

“Dede Ekeoma.”

“Mmm, my sisters, see you later.”

The girls picked their way carefully among the mounds and started their journey back home.

Ekeoma and Agana went back to their work. Oluoha put his goatskin bag on the ground to serve as a pillow and settled down to sleep off the meal. He slept until late afternoon.

The sun continued to shine relentlessly, and the weather became very hot. Agana was sure it would rain that night because heavy showers always followed such a hot day at that time of the year. They continued tilling the ground. It would take at least two more days of work to finish tilling the entire farmland. Agana wished they had called other young men for exchange labour. If they had, they would have finished tilling the entire farmland by the end of the day. But their father would not hear of it. He did not have anything against other young men

or the labor exchange, but disapproved of that for his children. He wanted his children to bear their burdens. He considered it a training in diligence and perseverance. They aimed to till one-third of the farmland on the first day and finish the entire land in the next two days.

At last, the sun began to set, and the sky that had been bright and blue turned grey. Thick clouds started crawling slowly over the grey sky. Oluoha called on his sons to hurry up and have their second meal so they would get home before it started raining. They hurriedly ate their meal and went to the nearby stream to take a quick bath. As they walked back home, the cloud continued its slow takeover of the sky above them. As they stepped into their compound, the rain came down in torrents as if it were waiting for them to get home. They all hurried into their father's Obu while the skies opened and cried her eyes out. Agana and Ekeoma fell into a restful sleep on the floor mat by the corner of the obu, while their father sat on his bamboo chair and brooded about what he would tell his children that night. He wondered if that would be the last rain he would see alive.

Chapter 3

After dinner, Oluoha called his children together, eight of them in all: Agana, Ekeoma, and his six daughters. They were aged between nineteen and seven.

“The story I am about to tell you now, some of you already know, while some don’t. Some of you are even too young to comprehend it, but I will still tell it anyway. I called you girls too because I believe you will bring honour to my name someday when I am long gone.”

“Do you know how this village came to be? You don’t know, so let me start from the beginning. Okoro, my great-great-grandfather, gave birth to many sons, and the land where they lived across the river became too small for all of them. One day, Dike, the eldest son of his second wife, went in search of an uninhabited land so that his children and grandchildren would have enough space to live and farm. For over three market days, he did not come back; his wives became worried. Just when they were beginning to despair, he came back with the news that there were vast arable lands across the Obohu River. He told them that before coming back, he had already built huts that would accommodate every member of his family. A few days later, Dike and his two wives and four children started the journey across the river and settled in this land that is today known as Amachara. His brothers and their families later came over to also settle in this village. When his stepbrothers saw that there were other uninhabited lands near Amachara, they too moved

their families to the surrounding villages of Abali, Nkwo, Uba, and Ekwule; that is why we do not intermarry.”

“When my grandfather was old, he shared the land among his ten sons, and my father, Amadi, got his own share. As you know, I am the only male surviving son of my father, and I inherited all his farmlands. By diligence and determination, I have been able to hold on to all my father’s farmlands, and because of this, some members of my extended family are envious, and today, some of them are waiting to grab my farmlands when I’m gone. But I have made sure anyone who tries that will pay dearly.”

“Nnayi, why are you saying, when I’m gone? Where are you going?” Chioma, his eight-year-old daughter, asked.

Oluoha smiled and didn’t answer.

“You already know the story of how I lost my first family, so I will not repeat it. I bore the adversity, today I have lived to see my sons grow up, and my daughters too. If I die tonight, don’t weep too much. I have lived an accomplished life. All I want you to do is to work hard and live fulfilled lives yourselves. There is no substitute for hard work, diligence, and perseverance.

I’m talking especially to you, my sons, be smart, be vigilant; I will not be with you for long before I go my way. Be strong and courageous. And look after your mothers and sisters. When I’m gone, if you need any advice, you can always go to Esiaga. He is the first son of my bosom friend, Agu. His father and I were like brothers. I have already pleaded with him to be a father to all of you when I’m gone.”

“Nnanyi, where are you going?” Chioma asked again.

“You can all go and sleep. It’s going to be a busy day tomorrow. I can see Akunna and Uche are already asleep.”

“May the daybreak.”

“May the daybreak,” everyone said to the other. Diadi and Ugwuezi reached down and carried the two sleeping children to their respective rooms.

Agana stayed behind because he wanted to tell his father about his dreams. As he finished telling the dream, his father smiled and said, “be strong, you will survive.”

Still, with a smile on his face, Oluoha settled on his ‘mkpoko’ to sleep.

Agana left his father’s Obu puzzled. That was neither the answer nor the reaction he had expected. He walked slowly to his room.

The room he shared with Ekeoma was spacious and it was always cool during the day and night. It was built with baked mud with two small windows. The roof was made of dried palm wine fronds. The door was short, and a tall person stooped to pass through it. The walls of the insides of the hut gleamed from a recent polishing of watery mud mixed with camwood. Both mothers took turns to ensure that their sons lived decently.

Agana lay down and left the door open. Cool air wafted in from the cold breeze outside. The moon was shining bright, there were no kids outside today telling stories or playing because the ground was still wet, and it was cold outside. He could not sleep. He lay face up, staring at the rooftops. He felt sad but did not know why. Was it the dreams? He had been having the dreams for some time now, but it never made him sad. He usually felt upset when he woke up, but would forget about

it before breakfast. But today it had been different. The dream had remained vividly in his mind.

His eyes focused on the bamboo on the roof where the stalks were tied together, and he noticed that weevils had started eating the wood. That meant he would have to go and cut some fresh bamboo palm fronds and change that part of the roof as soon as they finished with the farm. With that thought on his mind, he drifted off to sleep.

Chapter 4

A week later, Agana woke up early and looked closely at the wood on the roof. Tiny dust particles floated down from the spot where the weevils were eating off the bamboo wood. Agana picked up his knife. Today was as good a day as any to start the repairs. It was supposed to be their rest day before they started clearing the next farmland, but the roof needed attention before the rains became more frequent.

"Nnam, where are you going?" Ugwuezi asked her son.

"I want to cut some bamboo to replace the one on the roof. Weevils have nearly eaten up the woods holding the roof in the middle."

Oluoha stepped out of his room as Agana headed out.

"Ekeoma."

"Yes Nnayi."

"While Agana cuts the bamboo and palm wine fronds for the roof, you will cut palm fronds for the temporary shed we will build inside the compound."

"Nnayi, did you say a shed? What do we need a shed in the compound for?"

"Agana."

"Nnayi."

"You will need to cut more of the bamboo and palm wine fronds to make thatch. All the roofs need to be touched up. We can change all the thatch on the roof, can't we?"

"Yes, Nnayi."

“So cut a good portion. I will help you with the weaving so we can finish changing the roofs early before the rainy season starts in earnest. As you know, the road to ‘Ude’ is usually busy as soon as the sun is up, I want you to hurry and come back before the rest of the villagers.”

As Agana and Ekeoma walked the road to the ‘Ude’, they held their breath. They did not want to admit to themselves that they were afraid. Agana could hear the ‘thump thump’, beating of his heart. This track road was eerie, especially in the early hours of the morning. There were too many frightening stories about this road. The fact that it also led to the boundary between Amachara and the next village, where human sacrifices were made long ago, added to their discomfort. The ground was uneven due to erosion and long usage. It was the oldest route from Amachara to Umuafor, where slave poachers and traders used to carry out their nefarious trade. All these added to the danger the track portended, real or imagined.

“Agana, are you afraid?”

“Me, afraid of what?” Agana tried to sound as confident as he could, though they both knew he was putting on a brave front.

“I’m scared, I wish Nnayi had come with us, even if it was for the company.”

“Ekeoma, you know that Nnayi is old. He needs to rest; he can’t continue accompanying us to every task. We are old enough to do this on our own.”

“What do we even need the palm fronds and palm wine fronds for anyway? Why do we need a temporary shed inside the compound? We’ve done so much work and have more to do at the farm; we should have had the day off after the hard work at the farm yesterday.”

“Stop complaining, cutting the palm tree fronds is easy enough. I have a tougher job to do on top of the palm wine tree, with the sharp edges I have to avoid.”

“Sh sh sh, Ekeoma whispered, I heard something, it sounds faint, but it could be anything. We should be ready to dive into the bush at any minute.”

“Stop it, Eke, we are too old for that. Besides, we are not the only people using this road at this time of day.”

“Sh sh sh, listen, listen, can’t you hear it?”

“Eke, stop the joke.” Agana slowed down, listening hard to pick up any sound.

“I thought you said you were not afraid.” Ekeoma countered, laughing.

“I’m not afraid.”

“See who is talking, why is your voice quivering?”

“My voice is not quivering. In any case, you know the adage that says, the brave suffer from fright.”

“I hear you, let’s go. We are afraid and we know it.”

“I am not afraid.”

They walked to the swampy piece of land called ‘Ude’, a choice property in all the communities. Anyone who had two or three ‘Ude’ alongside other farmlands was regarded as wealthy. Oluoha owned about six of them. It took a great deal of hard work to maintain an ‘Ude’. The palm-wine trees needed constant trimming and preparation to ensure a good yield of palm wine all year round. The palm-wine tree called ‘Ngwo’ had diverse uses. The branches were woven into thatches and used for roofing. The wine, usually sold every morning, brought much income to the family. When the trunk is cut down after it has

stopped yielding, it is left to breed a kind of edible lava called 'eruru', a delicacy children loved very much. The two brothers set about their business.

"Agana, be careful and don't fall off the tree. I can't carry you all the way home." Ekeoma teased.

"See who's talking, don't worry, I will not fall, be careful yourself."

By the time they were through cutting and tying the wood and fronds into bundles, the sun was up. They carried the bundles up the hill to the track road in five trips. When they took the last bundle up, some young boys offered to help them carry some bundles home.

"Welcome, Nnam, Ugwuezi greeted her son Agana. "You are home early. Did you cut these bundles within this short period? You left not long ago."

She turned her attention to the children, "Welcome, welcome, my children. Just throw the bundles down. They will arrange them later. You've done well, my children."

"You will wait and have breakfast with us boys." Agana offered the boys as he threw down his bundle.

"Thank you, dede, we have eaten, the oldest of the boys answered."

"Okay then, what else do we offer you?"

"Some helpings of 'aku' will do."

"Alright, aku it is then. Nne, please give them a sizeable portion of aku, they have been of great help to us today."

"Come, come my children, come and help yourselves with the aku. It is by the corner of the kitchen down there." Ugwezi said, pointing at the palm kernels.

“Let’s be quick, let’s be quick, Chika urged the others. Let’s take the aku before nnayi Oluoha wakes up.”

“Who said Oluoha was sleeping in the first place?” Oluoha said, coming out of his room. I don’t bite, you know.”

“Nnayi, nmama.” The children chorused nervously.

“Yes, my children. So, you are strong enough to carry these bundles. I see you will become great men in this village someday if you continue in this manner. Ugwuezi, give them a good portion of aku, they deserve it.”

The children exchanged glances and smiled. They loved to see Oluoha in this relaxed mood, which was rare. All the children in the village revered and feared Oluoha because of all the stories they heard about him. They basked in his praise and commendation.

The next day, Oluoha called in two hired help to assist with the weaving of the palmwine fronds, and they readily accepted because he paid them handsomely on such rare occasions. He could afford to hire them permanently, house and feed them, or even own them if he wanted, as some of his kinsmen did, but he chose not to do so. Oluoha, his sons, and the hired help started weaving the fronds into roof thatches. They were at it for three days, starting at dawn and stopping in the evening. They only took short breaks at intervals to eat and stretch their legs, and to drink water. At the end of each day’s work, Oluoha brought a gourd of palm wine and drank along with his sons and his hired help before they would retire for the night.

On the fourth day, they changed the rotten wood and the rooftops of their room, checked for leakages on the other rooftops, and changed the thatches where needed.

Oluoha pointed to the part of the compound where they would build the shed. They still could not understand why their father needed a shed to be built. Ekeoma repeated the question.

“Why do we need to build this shed, Nnayi?”

“Ekeoma my son, there are times when you need to keep your questions in your mind, you can’t always have answers to everything.”

“Eke, Nnanyi said...”

“Nnayi, don’t you think you should go and rest? You’ve done enough work this past week; you deserve to rest for three full days.” Ada’s high-pitched voice cut off Agana mid-sentence.

“Yes, Ada, when we are done today, I will take a long rest,” Oluoha replied.

As they were putting the finishing touches to the shed, Oluoha got up, smacked his buttocks, walked slowly to his room, and lay down on the bamboo bed. His sons and the hired help finished a few hours later. They drank up the palm wine in the gourd, and the helpers left with a promise to come back anytime they are needed. Agana and Ekeoma went to their rooms to have a well desired rest.

Chapter 5

“Diadi, Diadi, come ooo, come and see what I am seeing.” Ugwuezu cried out from the entrance of Oluoha’s room.

Ugwuezi looked confused and agitated. Diadi quickly dropped her broom and ran towards the room. Oluoha lay still on the bamboo bed. The two women looked at each other and Diadi let out a scream. “Dede Olu what has happened to you? Have you left us? Is this the way you chose to leave us?” She cried.

Ugwuezi sat quietly beside Oluoha on the bamboo bed and wept quietly. She was the younger of the two wives and the mother of Agana and Atuma. She felt the blow of the death of her husband, but her calm disposition would not let her shout the way Diadi was shouting. Agana and the rest of the children, on hearing Diadi’s cry, ran to their father’s room, but Diadi stopped the young ones from entering the room. She quickly pulled herself together and herded the young children back to her room. Children were not allowed to see a corpse. They were not to see the corpse until ‘Nzu’ had been rubbed on their faces. If that is not done, the dead person will frighten them at night to show his annoyance.

Everyone was crying, the young and old, including the children who did not understand what the crying was all about. Before long, the compound was filled with extended family members and sympathizers. The death of Oluoha spread through the entire village of Amachara and its environs. It was the exit of one of the greatest men of their time.

Agana and his brother sat on their father's Obu with their hands crossed over their chests. Both were too dazed to cry. Their father must have had a premonition of his death, and he was prepared. He remembered what their father had said the night he called them together and the serene look on his face as Agana walked out of his room. They now understood why he insisted they build the shed and change the old thatched roofs.

Agana was comforted that their father died a fulfilled man. He also died as the warrior that he was. He was active and worked till his death. He did not lie down sick needing attention like most people.

Agana was filled with unexpressed grief and foreboding. At seventeen he was too young to carry the responsibility of taking care of his family, though he had been trained and nurtured to face this possibility as far back as he could remember. He suddenly felt old and lonely.

"Agana my son, how are you?"

Agana looked up and saw Nweke sitting opposite him. He had not noticed when he came and sat close to him.

"I am well, dede," he answered.

Nweke sat and tapped his feet on the floor and nodded his head in unison. He watched Agana from the corner of his eye. Agana always felt uneasy with this man, who was one of his uncles. Even now, as he sat there, Agana felt rather than saw the look of triumph in Nweke's eyes. He looked like a lion ready to pounce on prey, but was bidding his time. Although Oluoha always talked about his kinsmen being envious of his wealth and accomplishments, Agana could not point to any of them as the culprit, but something about Nweke disturbed him. And now, while

others came and expressed their sympathy and condolence, Nweke just exchanged greetings with him and sat down without saying another word. Agana instantly knew he had to be wary of Nweke more than anybody else.

Diadi crushed some lumps of 'nzu' and mixed them with water, and rubbed it on the brows and cheeks of the younger children so they would not have nightmares or dreams of their father. It was believed that if the dead did not see the nzu on the faces of the children, they would get angry and frighten the children to show their anger. Oluoha's two wives changed their clothes and wore old, worn-out clothes, and sat on the mat on the floor in their respective rooms. Their relations came around to stay with them, and other women came to mourn with them.

"Nnayi, Ogbo, have you heard what I'm hearing?" Ogbo's wife asked him.

"Heard what?" Ogbo slowly turned on his side to stare at his wife.

Ogbo was Oluoha's best friend, both were visiting each other regularly until Ogbo fell off a palm tree while cutting down palm fruits and hurt his spine and became bedridden. He stared at his wife, who stood at the entrance of his room, and hesitated to answer him. Ogbo's wife debated with herself whether she should tell her husband right away. She mentally scolded herself for bursting into the room of her sick husband with bad news without thinking.

"Heard what?" Ogbo asked again impatiently, his voice rising.

"Nnayi, Dede Oluoha is dead."

“Cheeeeeei,” Ogbo let out in agony and closed his eyes. His wife rushed to his side with a frightened look. She saw that he was still breathing and slowly sat on the low stool in the room. The grief of Oluoha’s death was heavy in the room. Ogbo kept his eyes shut for a long time. He had hoped that at his death, Oluoha would be the one to ensure he was given a decent burial because he had no son, but that hope has been shattered.

Chapter 6

The condolence visits continued for several days, along with the plans for the burial of Oluoha. Two days after Oluoha's death, Agana and his brother engaged the village town crier to formally invite the men of the village to Oluoha's compound. On the fifth day, the men and the elders went to answer the call. The old men went with their bamboo stools and their goatskin bags hanging over their shoulders. The old men sat around in the obu while the younger men stood at the inner compound listening to what was being said. They were served kolanut by Ekeoma. He gave the kolanut bowl to the oldest man in the room.

"Nnayi, this is kolanut." Emenike took the kolanut bowl and presented it to everybody.

"Ehe, Amachara, this is kolanut." He lifted the bowl and waved it around for everyone to see. All the people replied that they have seen it. Emenike passed the bowl around to the elders in the obu until the kolanut bowl came back to him. Emenike gave the bowl back to Ekeoma. Ekeoma gave the bowl to the youngest man in the room, who cut the kolanuts into bits and shared them among everyone present. When everyone had been served, Eru got up to address the men.

"Umunnam kwenu."

"Eh."

"Umunnam Kwenu."

"Eh."

"Umunnam Kwezuenu."

"Eh eee."

“We all know why we are here. This is to formally inform you of the death of Oluoha, whom you all know. His sons, their mothers, and the extended family have agreed that Oluoha will be buried four days from today. Help us pass the information to others. We also implore you to help us in any way you can, as is the tradition. Our people say that one person does not bury the dead. Thank you all for coming.”

Emenike slowly stood up and greeted everyone, and addressed the men.

“Thank you, Eru. It is our tradition and culture to help one another in times of bereavement, and this will not be different. Before I go further, we want to know if Oluoha’s maternal relations have been formally informed of his death?”

“Yes, we took a he-goat and several tubers of yam to the oldest relative of his mother.”

“And what did they say?”

“They will come in the morning on the day of his burial to indicate the spot where we will dig his grave.”

“You know I asked all that for formality, we all know that mother is supreme, he is their son, he cannot be buried without their consent.”

Emenike continued addressing the men.

“Our people say that when the right hand washes the left hand, the left hand will wash the right hand. Oluoha has washed many hands in Amachara, it is our duty to wash his. We will all ensure that he is given a befitting burial. Amachara men have I spoken for you?”

“Eh, nnayi Emenike, we are all in support of all you have said.”

Emenike told a few stories of the things that Oluoha did in his younger days, which he was privy to, especially the funny stories. The younger men were amused by some of the anecdotes he told and were amazed at

some of the exploits which they had never heard before. The elderly representatives of the five kindreds all stood up to tell some of the stories they knew about Oluoha. As dusk began to set. Emenike stood up again to speak.

“The five kindreds in Amachara will each start rendering help in whatever way they can, from tomorrow till the day of the burial. Ekeoma and Agana, you are not alone, the men of Amachara are all behind you.”

Eru thanked everybody on behalf of his nephews, and the elders left. Some of the younger men stayed a little longer, telling jokes, and left later.

On the morning of the burial, Oluohia’s maternal relations came with a hoe and dug a little hole on the spot where he would be buried, as was the custom. The young men in the village came to dig the grave. They were given one he-goat and several tubers of yam. When the digging was completed, they cooked the goat and yam tubers and yam tubers and shared it amongst themselves. By mid-afternoon, all the villagers and relations, far and near, gathered for the burial.

During the burial, Esiaga stood up to give the oration.

“My brethren, we are gathered here to lay to rest our brother Oluoha, who has joined our ancestors. Our people say that the best gift you can give a dead man is to give him a befitting burial. That is what we have come here to do. Oluoha died at the age of ninety-two, which is a ripe age to die, though we know some of our brothers had died at one hundred and ten and beyond. But ninety-two years is also a good age to die. The death of our brother marks the exit of a great man.

Oluoha was a great man. I can say that of him. He had his good qualities and weaknesses, as any other mortal. I admire him most for his kindness and strength of character. Here lies a man who lost all sixteen members of his first family, sixteen children, and four wives, to the dreaded chicken pox. He bore his loss and grief as a man. He grieved and mourned, but persevered and triumphed and lived to marry again and raise a family again. Let me not bore you with stories that you all know. But I must say this, those of you who are rejoicing over the death of Oluoha with the hope of inheriting his farmlands, let me remind you that Oluoha has two sons who are alive and well. Secondly, let me also warn you that men like Oluoha do not die with their eyes closed. That is all I have to say."

A murmur went through the crowd. The members of the Ege family were particularly angry at the concluding statement. They knew it was directed at them. The elders of Amachara knew the story of how some members of the Ege family were envious of Oluoha's farmlands and wanted to annex some of them. But nobody has said it openly as Esiaga had done. Esiaga was a warrior himself and was confident that nobody dared challenge him for what he said. Oluoha was buried with all traditional rites with the support of his friends, relations, and the elders of Amachara.

After his burial, his wives shaved their hair and put on mourning clothes which they would wear for a year from the day their husband was buried. By the end of one year, they would burn their mourning clothes to signify that their mourning has ended. The hair of his female children was shaved as well. Agana and Ekeoma had the option of

either leaving their hair or shaving it, they both shaved their hair along with the rest of the family.

Ten months later, Agana and his brother harvested the yams from the farm, their mothers and siblings helped wash the yams, and carried them home. They left the cassava to be harvested at a much later date. A few days later, Agana tied the yam tubers up in the yam barn; the big tubers were tied at the top layers, and the medium-sized and small tubers were tied in that order. They missed the presence of their father, who was always at hand during this period to direct them on what to do.

Chapter 7

The New Yam Festival at Amachara and the surrounding villages was a big deal. It was the time of year when the people expressed their gratitude to God for giving them a good harvest. It was celebrated with food and dance, relations from far and near came to felicitate with extended family members and friends. Young men and women learned new songs and dance steps, which they displayed on the day of the festival.

One year after his father's death, Agana was ready to join in the celebration of the new yam festival once again. His friends were practicing a new dance, and he was practicing with them. Agana sat with ten of his peers from the village in his father's Obu. They were practicing 'Ijaw' songs and dance, a new dance that is yet to be known in the village.

The 'Uko' dance was usually performed during the New Yam festival, but this time around, some of the young men in the village decided to add variety to the musical presentations, so they invited a few Ijaw dancers who lived across the big river to teach them the dance. For two months, they practiced the dance in secret. Agana was selected to play the 'ekpete' because of his dexterity in playing the same instrument in the Uko dance. The novel idea of the dance and Agana's involvement helped him to take his mind off his father's death and the responsibilities he has in the family. It has been one year and a few weeks since the death of his father, though the mourning period was over, he was still grieving.

Agana played the instruments and at intervals joined the dance. On this day, they chose to practice in his house. After playing the instrument for a while, Agana stepped out from behind the drums, bent to his waist, took a few steps backward and two forward, moving his waist to the beating of the drums to the admiration of the others in the group, five other young men joined him, and the dance practice became animated.

“What type of feminine dance is this, and where did you learn it from?”

Agana and the others looked up to see his friend Ochonga standing at the entrance of the Obu.

“Ochonga, welcome, my friend, how did you sneak in without anyone noticing?”

“As if you don’t know, they are called the children of the night, darkness covers them as they walk,” the young men joked.

“You have not answered my question.”

“Sit down my friend, you should not have seen us in the first place, as such, you don’t ask questions about things you shouldn’t know.”

Ochonga sat down on the bamboo chair.

“Agana, we have to go now since we cannot continue our dance in front of your visitor. We will see you later in the evening,” the dance team leader said as he left with the rest of the dancers. Agana was left alone to attend to his friend.

Ochonga looked around the Obu and saw that the interiors had changed. There were now four rectangular bamboo chairs positioned at the four ends of the Obu, forming a square. The bamboo was dyed with camwood, and a secular stool with a smooth surface stood in the middle

of the room. The round stool in the middle of the obu with the 'okwa' – the kolanut bowl- on top of it, was also new.

"It appears you like the new look of our Obu."

"Yes, I do, how did you achieve the colour on the bamboo? I know it takes about two months to make the stools. It not not quite two months since I last visited here."

"You have to pay for a consultation to get the answers."

"Me, pay you to get an answer? That means you don't want to tell me."

"There are ideas you don't get for free."

"Okay, I see you don't want to tell me."

"How are you, my friend? I can see you are looking better than the last time I saw you. Seems like you have been eating a lot of the harvested yams." Agana changed the subject.

"You are looking better yourself."

"Are you sure I'm looking better?"

"Sure, you are."

"Well, if you say so. How was the yam harvest this year in Umuda?"

"We had a good harvest. All the harvested yams are quite sizable, and I just finished stocking up my yam barn."

Agana brought bitter kola and drew the stool close to Ochanga. "Have some bitter cola, it is what we have now. Nne will buy kola nuts on her way back from the market."

"I can eat anything; I am not a visitor in this house, you know that."

"Yes, I know, but have some anyway."

"You know why I'm here, Agana. Have you made up your mind to give me the gun?"

“Ochonga, I have been thinking about your request these past two months and you know why I’m hesitating to give it to you. It is my prized possession and there are not many of it around.”

“I know all that, my friend, I will take good care of it.”

“You must promise me that you will handle it with care.”

“I promise with my life that I will use it with care. I just need to join the hunters this season. As soon as the hunting season is over, I will return it.”

Agana entered his father’s hut and brought out the gun under the bamboo bed. He had not gone hunting since his father’s death. The gun was slightly covered with dust and cobweb. He carefully cleaned the gun with a cloth wipe his father kept at the end of the bed. He looked around the room. It has remained the same since their father’s death. The room rightly belonged to Ekeoma, but he has not moved into it, that was why the gun was still under the bed.

Oluoha gave the gun to Agana as a gift when he was fifteen. That year, during the farming season, their father gave the two brothers a portion of farmland each and promised that whoever finished clearing and planting his portion all by himself would get the gun as a reward. That was the first time they each had to clear and cultivate farmland all by themselves. Agana worked as he had never done before and finished five days before his brother. His father gave him the gun as he had promised. Agana learned how to hunt that same year from his father. The time he spent with his father during that training drew them closer. His father told him stories about his forefathers and the village, and his late wives and children. He learned a lot from the conversations they had.

He still felt reluctant about giving Ochonga the gun, but he promised him he would give it to him two months ago. He regretted making that promise, but he did not want to go back on his word. All he could do now was hope that Ochonga will handle the gun well. He walked into the Obu with the gun.

"Here is the gun." Agana stretched out his hand to hand the gun over to his friend. Ochonga's eyes lit up as he sprang up from the chair to take it. The thought of having the gun all for himself for two weeks made him feel lightheaded. How he had longed to own a gun.

"Thank you, Agana, you are a good friend. I will guard the gun with my life and return it to you in two market days." Ochonga headed towards the door.

"Not so fast, Ocho, you will need to wrap it and conceal it, you cannot go all the way to Umuda carrying a gun like that."

"It's true, my friend, I got carried away."

"We will go to the back of the house and get some dried bananas leave and wrap it up."

"Yes, let's go."

They both went behind the house, pulled down some dry banana leaves, wrapped the gun with it, and used some dried stalk to tie it up.

"Agana, my friend, I have to go now before it gets dark."

"Won't you wait for Nne to come back so you have something to eat before you go?"

"No, my friend, with this gun, I feel my stomach is full already."

"I hope you will come and visit us during the New Yam festival."

"Yes, yes, I will come."

"Greet your people for me when you get home."

“I will, my friend. We will see again during the New Yam festival.”

As Ochonga left with the gun, Agana suddenly felt sad. He wondered if he had become too attached to the gun. That would be in bad taste. He did not want things like that to have a hold on him. He made up his mind to leave the gun with Ochonga longer than he requested

Chapter 8

On the day of the festival, different types of meals were prepared. Breakfast consisted of yam, cooked with delicious spices and dried fish. The main dish was ukazi soup cooked with egusi, dried beef, chicken, and dried fish, which usually goes with pounded yam.

Agana bought a sizeable quantity of kolanut and bitter kola for the expected visitors from far and near. He put the nuts in the outer space of the 'okwa' and poured the spiced sauce, which his mother prepared, into the centre of the 'okwa' and covered it. It was his first time overseeing such a duty, and he wanted the visitors to be properly entertained, exactly as it used to be when his father was alive. As the male visitors arrive, they would sit in the Obu while the women and girls would go into the compound to be entertained by their mothers and sisters. As he put the finishing touches on the Obu, Ekeoma came in with two gourds of palmwine. The village tapper had pruned the palm wine trees earlier in the year, and the palmwine trees were producing excellent wine.

"Agana, bring the 'nkuku' and let us taste this wine before anyone else."

"Yes, my brother, it is the tradition." Agana reached for the wooden cups and set them on the middle stool. Ekeoma poured some wine into the two cups, and they drank.

"Mm, this palm wine is excellent."

"It has always been this good. I hope the wine will be enough for the visitors."

“I believe so, I don’t think we will have a lot of people visiting since they know we just came out of mourning.”

“That is true, but you never know.”

“I will eat some kolanut and see how good it goes with the sauce.”

“Nne overdid herself with this sauce. I’ve had some already.”

“Mm, this sauce is super, it has the right quantity of spice.”

“I told you so.”

They both ate some more of the nuts and sat down to wait for the visitors. Ochonga was the first to arrive, followed by Esiaga and his wife, but none of their children. Soon after, other relations started arriving with little bags of gifts containing mainly Kolanuts and anara. The men brought kolanuts while the women brought anara. Their hosts washed the nuts and fruits and added them to the ones they already had. As Ekeoma predicted, they did not have many visitors as they usually did.

When everyone has been served food and drinks, they rested for a bit and started heading to the village square for the main event of the festival which was the dance.

The villagers and their visitors filed to the village square in twos and threes. The girls were chatting excitedly as they trekked to the dance arena. The new Ijaw dance was the talk of the village. The women and girls were dressed in plain check wrappers tied to their chests. The young girls plaited their hair halfway, with the hair shaft rounded out at the top like newly sprouted mushrooms. Colourful beads adorned their ears and necks. Their palms and heels were dyed with camwood. The older women walked leisurely to the arena and stopped intermittently to

greet other women and relatives, while the young girls hurried to the arena, absorbed in the excitement of the day.

At the village square, the Ijaw dance group was already seated and beating their drums in the middle of the square. The Uko dance group was seated at the other end of the square.

The Ijaw dance group members were dressed in white shirts and white and red check wrappers tied to their waists. They looked resplendent compared to what the villagers were used to. This added to the attraction.

The people trooped to the Ijaw dance side of the arena to have a glimpse of the young men and listen to the new songs and dance; fewer people than normal were seen on the side of the Uko dance group. The spectators formed a semicircle around the Ijaw dancers. The drummers were playing and singing while the dancers displayed rare dance steps. They shook their waist to the rhythm of the music and made a semi-circle sweep, like a kite about to snatch a chicken, to which everybody clapped. Within a short while, most of the spectators joined in the dance. The dance went on till late evening. The next day, the youngsters continued with the dance and celebrations, while the elders came and went at their convenience. The Ijaw dance remained the talk of the village for a few more days.

Chapter 9

"Have you heard that the boy Agana lent his gun, killed a boy with the gun?"

"How, when, where?"

"Which one do you want me to answer now? I just told you what I heard. They said Ochonga, that's the boy's name, went hunting and accidentally shot another boy, who was also hunting with his mates."

"God forbid, what is going to happen? What will the boy's relations do?"

"That is the worst part of the news. You know how mean-spirited Umuda people can be. They are asking for an eye for an eye."

"Well, that is their problem. It is between Umuda and Umuako. Let them settle that between themselves."

"Are you living in this village at all? Eziaku lowered her voice. "Have you not heard that Agana's kinsmen are planning to offer up Agana instead?"

"What? Where has it ever happened before? That cannot happen. Eziaku, you and your mouth, don't let your tongue put you in trouble one day."

"Urunma, my sister, that is the rumour that is going around the village. We will put our ears to the ground and see how events will unfold."

"By the way, Eziaku, I heard your stepdaughter is getting married."

"Yes, my sister, at last, somebody is coming for her."

"When are our in-laws coming for the marriage rites?"

"It is tomorrow evening."

"Tomorrow, and you are just telling me now? Were you waiting for me to ask first?"

"No, my sister, I wanted to be sure that they are coming. I want to see the suitor and his people with my eyes before I spread the news. I want to see the man who wants to marry the old girl before I tell anybody."

"Why is her mother keeping it under wraps?"

"Have you forgotten her nickname, Ala? She knows how to hide things." Both women laughed.

"My sister I'm going to the market square to buy some salt and crayfish. I need to hurry; I will see you tomorrow."

"See you tomorrow, my friend."

Agana, his mother, his stepmother, his siblings, and half-siblings all sat together in the Obu. The news of Ochonga's manslaughter had spread throughout the village, and the planned treachery of his kinsmen was now an open secret. They heard through one of his uncles that some representatives of the elders of Umuda had meetings with the elders of the Ege family twice in the past week, and Agana was not invited to any of the meetings. Ochonga on his part, had not shown up either. Only his parents came to see Agana and his family. They brought the news to Agana that it was his kinsmen who had offered to give him in exchange for the death of the boy from Umuako, since it was his gun that was used in the shooting. They also told him that the elders of Umuako confiscated the gun. Despite their plea and expression of sadness, Agana could see the relief on their faces, they were not about to lose a son after all. It was obvious they were secretly grateful that Agana's kinsmen had inadvertently saved their son from death.

Ugwuezi was sad and too frightened to say a word. The possibility of losing her son a year after her husband's death was too much to contemplate. She sat on the floor, staring into space.

"What are we going to do?" Diadi asked again for the umpteenth time, without getting an answer from anyone. Not that she expected an answer anyway.

Ada and Atuma sat at one end of the room, crying silently. Their world was falling apart, and nobody was giving a helping hand. Only Eru, their uncle, had come to reassure them that nothing will happen to Agana since there has not been an antecedent to what some of their kinsmen were proposing.

Agana knew that Eru's voice was a lone voice that would be drowned in the sea of his kinsmen's greed. He heard that a few others had also protested feebly on his behalf, but the force behind the plot was too powerful to budge. Agana had a plan of his own, and this brought him a measure of calmness. With this ray of hope, he no longer felt the depression that had threatened to overwhelm him in the last few days.

"Nne, I think you should all go and sleep. None of us had slept well these past few days. I believe it will be well, our Chi is not asleep, he will fight our battle for us and exonerate me."

"May God hear our prayer."

The women got up and slowly entered their different rooms with their children. Ada and Atuma stayed a little longer and left to their own rooms.

The next morning, Agana was summoned by his uncles to hear why he gave the gun to his friend. The elders of the Ege family were

seated in Nweke's inner compound because his Obu was too small to contain them. Nweke addressed Agana.

"Agana, we called you here today to hear your own side of the story about the boy who was killed in Umuda with your gun."

Agana stood up and looked around the gathering, staring at the faces of the men who sat there. Most of them looked away. They could not look him straight in the eye.

"My uncles, I think you already know what I have to say, but I will say it anyway. Ochonga is my friend, I will not deny that. He came to my house a few months ago and asked me to lend him my gun because he wanted to go hunting with it, along with other hunters from his village. I did not give it to him immediately, but he persisted. A few weeks before the New Yam festival, he came asking me again, and I gave him the gun and asked him to be careful with it. He had gone hunting with the gun several times before the day he accidentally shot the boy who died before he could be given any first aid. My uncles, Ochanga's parents, assured me it was an accident."

"That is not what we heard. Our sources told us that it is a well-known fact in Umuda that your friend's parents had a running feud with the dead boy's parents over a palm wine orchard. Ochanga used hunting as a disguise to settle a score. And you knew about it."

"My uncles, that is a lie. It is a fabricated story. Most Umuda people can attest to the truth."

"Ehe, you live here and know what most Umuda people would attest to?"

"Yes, my uncles, I have ears and I have sent people to make inquiries in Umuda since this new rumour started spreading."

Eru stood up. "Ege family kwenu, kwenu, kwezuenu.

"Iya." Some of them replied.

"We have heard Agana's side of the story. That is what we should have done earlier than now. Like he rightly said, we should invite some of the upright people in Umuda to come and tell us the truth?"

"Yes, I agree to that," Obi added.

"It is the right thing to do." A few voices agreed.

"Eru, sit down, nobody asked your opinion in this matter." Nweke barked at the protesting voices, he turned to Agana.

"Well, Agana, we have made our own inquiries and have been able to ascertain your involvement in the killing of the boy from Umuda, and we have offered to give you in exchange for his life. From today, you will be under close observation till the day of the exchange.

"Where has it ever been heard?" Eru shouted at Nweke, who ignored him.

"This is an abomination," added Obi

Several people started talking at the same time. Those who were against the decision were protesting vehemently, while those who were for it were drowning their protest with shouts and threats. Through it all, Agana remained calm. Eventually, calm returned to the gathering, and those who were for the decision prevailed, which was not a surprise to Agana. It reminded him of the idiom that says that 'an earlier agreed arrangement is affirmed with a nod'. His greedy uncles had already agreed on what they wanted to accomplish, calling him to defend himself was a sham, and was made for mere optics.

Agana was led out by the three young men who were to guard him till the day of the exchange. The young men were people from

Umuako, which was another shocking development. His uncles had made up their minds and had made all arrangements without hearing his side of the story.

Agana would stay in his father's Obu without leaving the compound for six days, on the night of the seventh day he would be taken to the tiny swamp on the route that separates Umuda from Amachara and would be handed over to the elders of Umuako who would take him to their shrine and kill him to appease their god.

As Agana was led into his father's compound, a wailing broke out among the women and children. The news of the verdict had preceded Agana and his entourage. His family had hoped it would not come to this, but their fears have been confirmed.

"Stop crying, stop crying. Crying will not change anything, would it?" Ekeoma quickly intervened and tried to console the women. He felt helpless himself, but had to put up a brave face.

The news spread throughout Amachara that evening. Some of the villagers went to Agana's compound to confirm the news. They stood a little distance from the Obu to listen to the wailing inside. The young men from Umuako stood guard outside the Obu and would not let anyone in. Once it was confirmed that his family had made the decision and set a date for the exchange, a mourning silence hung like a cloud over the village.

A greater number of Amachara people loved Agana. Everyone knew him to be an honest, hard-working young man. They knew that this was a great injustice and knew the reason for the decision. But they could not interfere. Some of them had tried to reason with some members of the Ege family who were behind the plotted injustice, but

their pleas fell on deaf ears. He was their son, and there was a limit to what they could do.

Chapter 10

On the evening of the set day for the exchange, the men who were selected to accompany Agana and representatives from Umuda and Umuako gathered in Nweke's Obu. Palm wine was freely served, as was done on such occasions. Guilt and acts of wickedness occasioned intoxication. They drank jars of palm wine to numb their senses. Agana was given palm wine to drink as well, but as he was served each cup of wine, he would take a sip of the wine and pretend to be drinking, when nobody was watching, he would keep the cup down close to his leg and pour the wine away with a slight movement of his leg and raise his cup to be filled again and again.

When it was a little past midnight, they set out for the exchange arena. One of the men started singing, and the rest joined. The half-moon above them cast a dim light all around. The road to the arena was a narrow track that was not wide enough for two people to walk side by side. They walked in a file. Agana was in the middle of the file. All members of the entourage were at different levels of intoxication. One after the other, they would stop and urinate. Agana also joined in urinating, and with each stop, he drew back and let a few of the men pass by him.

By the time they got halfway to the site, Agana was the last man in the line. He stopped again, pretending to urinate, and quietly sneaked into the nearby bush. He immediately dropped on all fours and started crawling as fast as the bulrushes could permit him without making the slightest noise. He made several turns in the bush, keeping in his head

the turn that would take him to his planned destination. When he knew nobody would hear the noise behind him, he stood up and started walking in a stooped position, tearing the bulrushes in front of him with both hands to allow for easy movement. He kept walking in a zigzag, keeping in his head the many turns he had taken and how to retrace his way. He had played this escape in his mind for the past two weeks.

As he got to the boundary where the Obohu river separated Amachara from the east, he started retracing his way to the main route to his destination. Nobody would be able to find him, and soon he would be on the trail to freedom.

The singing group got to the clearing where Agana would be formally handed over to the elders of Umuako and stopped. They made a circle and asked Agana to step into the circle so that the ritual of handing him over will begin. They waited for a few minutes, and nobody stepped into the circle. They frantically peered into the faces of one another and realized Agana was no longer in their midst. Most of them became sober in a flash.

“Where is Agana?” Nweke asked the night breeze. “What happened?”

“How could he have escaped?”

Questions flew freely without answers.

“Quickly, let’s split into three groups and search for him. He couldn’t have gone far. One group, made up of the young men, will go back all the way we came and search the surrounding bushes. Another group will search the route leading to his mother’s village. Go as fast as you can; that is the probable place he would run to. The third group will go

to Ohuru and see if he is headed that way. Nweke and I will wait for you here until you bring him back.”

Nweke looked at Akpa, surprised at the urgency in his voice. He has never seen the old man so agitated and yet in control. Akpa had been his strongest ally since the plan to take over Oluoha’s property began. He was the brain behind it all. But he had played behind the scenes all through the deliberations. He hardly spoke up during the meetings but would always stay behind to encourage Nweke on the cause they were pursuing.

Akpa looked around for a place to sit down. He knew it was going to be a long and probably futile wait. There was no place to sit.

Nweke stood beside Akpa and thought about the events of the past few weeks. How could they have let Agana slip out of their hands at the last minute? This was not ordinary. The gods must be on Agana’s side. Nweke realized that instead of feeling a great loss, he felt somewhat relieved. Agana running away and leaving the land for them was a better option than carrying the guilt of his death for the rest of his life. What he would do now is focus on how to ensure that Agana never comes back to Amachara.

“Akpa, I think we should go back home and wait for the search party in my Obu.”

“What do we tell the elders of Umuako if Agana is not apprehended?”

“What do we need to tell them? Their representatives are here and saw all that happened, if they like, they can continue with the search. As for us, we have done our own part.”

“What happens to our lands that we want to recover?”

“We will go ahead and recover them.”

“Maybe if we had waited for the full moon to come out, this wouldn’t have happened; somebody would have seen him trying to escape.”

Nweke was silent. He had thought about that a few minutes earlier. They could not have put off the exchange till the full moon was out. There was no time for recriminations now. They had to move ahead.

“Let’s go, Akpa, we will wait for the search party at my house.” They both walked slowly back to Nweke’s house.

Agana stopped abruptly as a pair of bright eyes stared at him. He nearly passed out with fright, but stood his ground. He took a few steps backward and dropped on all fours behind a cluster of perennial stalks. He peered at the eyes watching him, on a closer look, he realized it was an owl perched on the branch of an Ofeke tree. His heart sank. The appearance of an owl in any circumstance usually meant ill luck, unless one scared the owl away or killed it. He had to take a chance. He groped for something to throw at the owl. His hand circled on a hard, crusted sand; he threw it with all his might at the owl. “May your ill luck fly away with you,” he muttered silently. The owl flew away, and he stood up and continued his walk. He quickened his pace. He did not want to run in order not to make a noise. He was close to the Ohuru clan, but he kept to the bush tracks. He could not risk being seen by anybody at that early hour of the morning, he could be mistaken for a thief. He kept close to the bush track until he was a few meters away from Esiaga’s house, at which point he came out into the open path, and a few paces later, he stood in front of Esiaga’s Obu and knocked on the wooden door.

Chapter 11

"I have seen the trail he took", Chuka said to the members of his group who went back to the track road they came from. He had followed the trail back and forth twice before announcing his discovery. The others gathered around him and peered closely at the torn bulrushes.

"This must have been his point of entrance. If we follow this trail, we will catch up with him soon."

"Do you think he will be hiding in the bush waiting to be caught?"

"If he dropped out this far, he must be close to wherever he is heading by now. Let's go back and avoid the risk of a snake bite."

"Adindu, stop being a pessimist. We should be hurrying after our target instead of parrying words."

"Can't you see that the moon is receding, by the time we follow this trail to the main track road to Uga or Ohuru or Okaji, it would be completely dark?"

"Adindu, you can go back if you want; the rest of us men will complete this task." Chuka asserted, leading the way.

"Did I hear you say men? Have you been man enough to throw down anybody in a wrestling match?" Is it not an open secret that you are on a personal vendetta against Agana?"

"This is not the time and place for a quarrel." One of the men from Umuako chided them. "We have a task at hand, and we are here wasting time."

Adindu reluctantly followed the group, carefully picking his way. He was bitten by a snake as a child and had a secret phobia for snakes.

Agana knocked on Esiaga's Obu three times and waited. Esiaga got up on the first knock but did not answer, he picked up the gun he usually kept by his bedside and waited. Who could be at his door at this time of the night? It was just a little past the first cockcrow. No thief would dare knock on his door, and there has never been any robbery incident at Ohuru. Agana knocked again and whispered his name loud enough for anybody in the Obu to hear. Esiaga sprang up from his 'mkpoko' and quickly unlatched the door.

"Agana, what are you doing here at this time of the night?" he asked as he led him into his obu. Agana motioned to him to close the door and quickly narrated to him what transpired between him and his kinsmen. Esiaga was surprised and angry. He knew Agana's kinsmen wanted Oluoha's farmlands, but did not know they could go this far. He picked up his gun and went outside, and released three gunshots.

"Whoever says he is a man let him come to this house and look for Agana," he muttered darkly and went back into his Obu. Agana cringed as he heard the gunshots. He wished Esiaga had left that till daylight.

"Why didn't you tell me all the time this was happening?"

"You couldn't have done anything, Dede, and I deliberately kept you out of focus for this reason."

"Agana, my son, your Chi is alive. It is your Chi and your ancestors who are not sleeping that helped you do this successfully."

"Yes, Dede, I know."

The search party that went to Uga heard the gunshot from a distance away and tried to guess where the sound came from. The boundary of Uga and Ohuru was just a few yards away. They were

already in Uga village and were heading towards Agana's maternal home. They went back into the bush and listened and waited.

The search party, led by Chuka, also heard the gunshot and stopped in their tracks. The sound came too close.

"That must be Esiaga welcoming Agana. I told you this pursuit would be fruitless."

"It might not be Adindu. The sound may have come from Oloko, the nearest village to Ohuru."

"I'm almost certain it is Esiaga. His house is at the boundary between Uga and Ohuru. I know his house."

"Then we could go there and confront him. Agana is a fugitive who must pay for his wrongdoing."

"My brothers from Umuako, I am not here on a suicide mission. We were told to pursue Agana and bring him back if we could. We have done our part. We should go back and tell them he has sought refuge in Esiaga's house. That man would shoot at anyone who tries anything foolish."

"Adindu, we have not confirmed that he is there. We will go close-up and be sure that it is the situation."

"Chuka, you can go with whoever is willing to go with you. I will stay here and wait for you."

Chuka turned to three young men from Umuako to find out what they think. They shook their heads in resignation.

"There is no point following him into the man's house, we will go back and tell the elders and see what they have to say."

Chapter 12

Esiaga's eldest son woke up at the sound of the gunshot and stood up agitated. What was happening? Who was his father shooting at? He quietly opened his door and peeped outside, and listened, but heard nothing. He neither heard nor saw anybody. He tiptoed closer to his father's Obu and heard voices. He tried to make out how many people were talking. His mother opened her door and peeped with her daughter, Akunma, right behind her, also trying to see what was going on outside. Nwanna motioned to them to wait. He went closer still and heard voices discussing in level tones. That meant the gunshot was not directed at a thief. Nwanna hesitated; he did not know if his father would shout at him if he walked into his Obu uninvited. As far as Nwanna was concerned, his father was decidedly eccentric and unpredictable. He looked back and motioned to his mother and sister to come. It was better that they went into the Obu together; it would forestall any insane reaction from his father.

"Nnanyi, is everything alright?" Nwanna's mother asked at the door of the Obu.

"Yes, Yes, Enyidiya, come in, we have a visitor."

Enyidiya, Nwanna, and Akunma entered the Obu and saw Agana seated on the bamboo chair.

"Agana my son is that you? She peered closely at him. Is everything all right with your family?"

"Enyi, everything is not all right. Agana just escaped death by a hair's breadth. Some people planned to kill him, and he ran to us for refuge."

“They wanted to kill you. Why?”

“We will leave the details for now, Enyi. You will hear the details later in the day. Nwanna, Agana will stay in your room for now until we can build a hut for him.”

Nwanna stood there. He had not said a word since coming into the Obu. He did not like this intrusion into his privacy. He had just started an affair with Adaku, a girl from a nearby village, and was hoping he would soon woo her into his room. With Agana around, that would be impossible.

“Did you hear me, Nwanna?”

“Yes, Father. Agana, you are welcome.” His voice was anything but welcoming.

“Welcome to our home, Agana.” Agana looked at Akunma briefly and nodded. At least somebody in the room besides Esiaga was happy to have him around. Akunma and Nwanna had grown taller than he remembered them. Members of Esiaga’s family knew him well. They all came with their father to visit them during the New Yam festival and Ekpe dance festival until about three years ago, when they stopped. During such visits, Agana and his brother tried making friends with Nwanna without success. He was always uptight around his father and would not relax until they left. Agana saw that nothing had changed between father and son.

Before long, Esiaga’s extended family and other villagers trickled to his house to find out what the gunshot was all about. In a few days’ time, he would call the elders of Ohuru and formally tell them that Agana has come to seek refuge amongst them as was the custom.

From where they were hiding, the search party saw the movement in and out of Esiaga's compound. They looked at each other without saying a word and started back home. On their way back, they were joined by those who went to Uga. They all went back to Amachara in silence. They arrived at Nweke's house in the early hours of the morning, and Nweke dismissed them and asked them to come back the next day for a family meeting. The men from Umuda and Umuako went back to their respective villages without a protest

Chapter 13

“My kinsmen, we all know that Agana escaped to Esiaga’s house, and according to tradition, that means he has inadvertently surrendered whatever belongs to him to the larger Ege family.”

“According to which tradition?” Eru shouted from where he sat at the back. “What you did was an abomination, and you are adding abomination to abomination. Agana is not the first son of Oluoha. Ekeoma is the rightful custodian of his father’s farmlands. Are you not engaging in an act that will cut off your posterity?”

“It is your posterity that will be cut off, you lily-livered son of a slave.”

“Who is the son of a slave?”

“You are. Do you want someone else to tell you that your father was a slave to one of our forefathers?”

“Ege family, did you hear Nweke call me a slave in my father’s land? Nweke, is there anything you would not do or say to grab what does not belong to you?”

“It’s enough, both of you. Eru there is no point taking us back to issues that are immaterial. We are here to discuss the way forward, whoever is not comfortable with our deliberation is free to leave.”

Eru turned to stare at Oko in disbelief. So, he was also privy to this treachery. All along, Oko had been on the sidelines, neither consenting nor disagreeing with the others.

“Oko, so you have been part of this treachery all along and were waiting for the right time to show yourself? It is true that when the wind blows, one sees the anus of a chicken.”

“Eru, sit down, that’s enough, Oluoha’s choice farmland belongs to the Ege family. My father told me that Dike, his father, took part of the farmland that belonged to Onwuka, who was the rightful owner because Onwuka was an orphan. Now that he is dead, we will take back the farmlands that belong to Onwuka originally. We will cultivate it rotationally amongst us. Whoever is not comfortable with that should not participate in the cultivation.” Nweke said firmly.

“Ege family kwenu, kwezuenu. I agree that the lands belong to us, but we should exercise caution. It is too soon to start talking about taking back the lands now. It will look obvious to the people of Amachara that recovering the land was what informed our decision on Agana on the manslaughter incident. Let us give it some time. Maybe a year or two before we take them back.”

Nweke stared at Akpa in annoyance. Why was he stalling now that they had come this far? He stood up to counter Akpa’s suggestion.

“Ege family, there is no point in wasting time. It is better to do a smelly job and wash your hands clean than leave it until later. Nobody said we are going into the farmlands right away. We will inform Ekeoma not to go into the farmlands after this year’s harvest. Thereafter, we will start the rotational cultivation.”

“Did anyone hear Nweke say that this is a smelly job?”

“Eru, I think you should leave this gathering.”

“Come and carry me out.”

“We will also specify which farmlands we are taking and who will cultivate which. We do not have to call another family meeting for that.”

Egesi proffered.

“We all know the farmlands he took; the two large farmlands at Jikara that are adjacent to each other, the Ude at the boundary between Amachara and Umuafor, and the farmland at Ochie.”

“Who and who will start the cultivation first?” Egesi asked once more. It was obvious he was interested in being among the first set. A measured silence followed. Eru shook his head and got up to leave. Okoro and Ogbonna also got up and left.

Orji raised his hand, and Egesi also indicated his interest in being among the first people to cultivate the lands.

“Akukwe you will also join the first set. You deserve it. You have been helpful in running errands that helped our cause.” Nweke decided for him. Akukwe nodded his acceptance. His late father was among the poorest in the Ege family and the only small portion of land he owned was hardly able to feed him and his family.

“I will tap the Ude first,” Eke said as he raised his hand. He was a renowned palm wine tapper in the village. Everybody else wanted him to start first, so he would do the hard job of pruning the Ngwo trees.

“I, Akpa, and Agu will take over from the first set of people cultivating the land, and it will go like that until it goes around and comes back to Egesi. Ege family, are our minds together on this?”

“Yes, yes, we agree to our decision.”

The young men among them brought out the kegs of palmwine and started sharing.

Later that evening, Egesi and three other men went to deliver the message to Ekeoma. He clapped his hands together as he entered Oluoha’s Obu. “Is anybody home?” he called out. He stepped into the

inner compound while the rest waited in the Obu. "Is anybody in this compound?"

"Yes, dede Egesi," Diadi answered from her room and came out. She recognized Egesi's voice the first time but did not want to respond. Her face was expressionless.

"Is Ekeoma at home? We came to deliver a message." Egesi spoke up after a little hesitation when he realized Diadi was in no mood to greet them.

"Yes, he just came back from the farm. He is washing his hands and legs at the back of the house. I will let him know you are here."

Diadi went to where Ekeoma was washing up. He had already heard the exchange between his mother and the men and was scowling.

"Your kinsmen are here to deliver a message. We can guess what it's all about. Do not argue or make trouble with them. Nnanyi Oluoha will fight for himself. He is listening."

"I will not let them take my land. Nnanyi Oluoha was there when they nearly killed Agana. What did he do?"

"Sh sh, do not offend the spirit of the dead. Agana escaped, didn't he? Do you know who guided him in the night to his destination? Do as I tell you, my son. One person does not fight a crowd. Nnanyi Oluoha will retaliate. You will see."

Ekeoma stalked out to where the men waited. He did not care to greet them. He stood and eyed them coldly, looking from one to the other.

"The Ege family said we should tell you to take your hands off the farmlands at Ijikara as soon as you harvest what is already planted. You will also stop taping the Ude along Umuafor village. The farmland

originally belonged to the Ege family, and we have taken back what is ours. The Ege family has taken back what is theirs.”

“The Ege family has taken back what is theirs.” Ekeoma mimicked Egesi’s nasal voice.

“Where was Ege’s family when my father was alive? Why didn’t they take back the lands then? That was why you wanted to kill my brother. And you are shameless enough to come and deliver such a message.”

Akukwe started to say something, but Egesi waved him down with a motion of his hand.

“We came to deliver a message and you had better do as the Ege family says,” Egesi repeated and motioned to the others to leave. They were surprised at Ekeoma’s reaction. They had expected him to be docile after what happened to Agana.

“You will have to kill me too before you will take those lands,” Ekeoma shouted at their retreating backs. Diadi quickly came and pulled him back from going after them.

Chapter 14

"It feels good to have you in my house Agana. I have always admired you."

"Thank you, Dede."

"I know you have rested and settled down these past four months. Now that you are here you will help us in clearing the land for the upcoming farming season, and in the cultivation. I want to prepare your mind for that. You know my farmlands are bigger than your father's."

"How do you know Dede?"

"He showed me his biggest farmlands before he died."

"He did? I didn't know about that."

Esiaga smiled and a glint came into his eyes. He continued smiling and staring at nothing. Agana always felt uncomfortable around Esiaga anytime his eyes lit up as they did now. Agana at times wondered if Esiaga suffered momentary insanity and this bothered him. He always had the glint anytime he was angry or excited about something. Agana stood up to leave, Esiaga looked up as if he just woke up from sleep.

"We will start the clearing by next week and I will like you to invite your friend, Chidi, to join us now that he is around. I see you have become good friends."

"Yes, Dede."

Agana stepped out of the Obu to see his friend walking towards Esiaga's compound.

"White man, where have you been hiding all these days?" Agana stepped out into the courtyard to the greeting of his friend Chidi.

“Black man, where did you look for me?”

“I have been in this village for the past two days without so much as seeing your back.”

“That means you didn’t look at the right places.”

“Must I come to this house to see you? My friend, you should come out to the village square at times and chat with other young men like you.”

“Well, you know I’m still settling in.”

“How long will that take you? I am a stranger to Ohuru myself, and I feel as free as the rest of us.”

“You are not a stranger. Your mother is from Ohuru, and you have as much right as any other Ohuru man.”

“All the same, Agana, the young men in this village would like to see more of you.”

“Is that what they asked you to come and tell me?”

“No, but I am a prophet, remember? I know what is on the minds of people.”

“I see. I didn’t know you were one.”

“Now you know.”

“Well, Mr. Prophet, dede said I should ask you to come along with us and help clear his farmland by next week.”

“What if I didn’t come here today, and how does he know I will be in Ohuru?”

“You see, you are not the only prophet around here. Will you come along?”

“How much will he pay me?”

“You will discuss that with him.”

“Discuss with dede Esiaga? I will not. You brought the message, you should finish the negotiation.”

“Are you afraid of him?”

“I am not afraid of him. Only, I don’t know the time of day when he is sane and when he is not.” Chidi lowered his voice as he said the last sentence. They laughed and went out to join other young men at the village square.

As they set out to the bush clearing, Esiaga told the young men to carry water bottles and fill them with water, since there were no streams on the way to drink from. They did the clearing until it was a little past noon. Esiaga told them it was time to leave. Agana was relieved and surprised. The sun was high and scorching, yet it was early to leave compared to the time they spent on his father’s farmland. But he remembered they had a long way to walk home, with no stream to bathe in. They cleared and tilled all five farmlands, and the planting season came to an end without any attempt made by the Ege family to capture Agana. Agana also learned from Ekeoma that the Umuako people did not make any further demands on appeasing the death of their son. Agana wondered at times if it was all a setup. But he could find no answers to that since it did not make any sense for someone to kill his son to help the cause of other people.

He could sense Nwanna’s hostility grow as Esiaga's interest in him grew. He longed to improve the relationship between Nwanna and his father.

He wished he could find a way to make Nwanna like him and know that he is not a threat to him. But what would he do? He had been

trying to do that ever since he arrived without any result. He would find a way.

Chapter 15

“Agana, please come into my Obu, I want to rub minds with you on some issues.” Esiaga beckoned to Agana with his hand. He stood in front of his Obu with a half smile on his face. Two years have passed since Agana came to live in his house. Agana followed him into the Obu.

“Agana, our people say that when you are passing by and see people dancing on a cleared arena, join them and dance because you never know, the same spot may be overgrown with weeds the day you are ready to dance. That means one should take advantage of opportunities as soon as they show up. The request I am about to make might be too soon, but who knows what will happen tomorrow? Agana, I want to make you my heir. I want to adopt you as my son, and you will inherit all that belongs to me just like a first son.”

“No, dede.”

“Let me finish what I have to say. You and I know that Nwanna is lazy and weak. If I leave my property in his hands, I will not rest easy in my grave when I die. He will leave my lands uncultivated, and eventually they will fall into the hands of my enemies.”

“No, dede, I will not accept the offer. It is not right for me to take what does not belong to me. Your lands belong to Nwanna and his siblings. Remember you have other sons apart from Nwanna.”

“Yes, my other sons will welcome your leadership.”

“Dede, I know you love me, but usurping another man’s position is wrong. Everybody knows I am not from Ohuru. Even if I stay here for

the rest of my life, my children and their children will be taunted by other people until they go back to their roots.”

“All the same, think about my proposal. As soon as you agree, I will call my kinsmen and openly declare to them that I have adopted you as my first son.”

“Dede, I wish you would stop saying that. What if Nwanna overhears this conversation? He has not accepted me into the family, you know that. This will further fuel his hostility. And I think you are underestimating Nwanna. He is not as weak and lazy as you think.”

“Let me hear. He is my son, and I know what he is capable of. Nwanna does not know his right from his left. At his age, he cannot think of or execute any task, and you are telling me he is not weak and lazy.”

“No, Dede, I insist he is not. It is your fault that he appears weak.”

“What? My fault?”

“Dede, you do not give Nwanna any opportunity to do anything by himself. You did not bring him close to you as a boy. That is why he is not like you. He is frightened by your.....”

“Let me hear. Who has ever heard such a thing? A son should emulate his father, whether they are close or not.”

Esiaga’s eyes blazed with anger as they always did when anybody challenged him. Agana kept quiet. After a fleeting and tense moment, Esiaga continued.

“Well, Agana, think about my offer.”

“There is nothing to think about, Dede. My answer is no.”

“Who knows, one day you might change your mind.”

Agana shook his head and left the Obu. Though he understood that Esiaga loved him as a son, yet to openly tell him to stay and inherit

all he had when his sons and daughters are alive was going too far. That will not happen. Even if he were foolish enough to nurse the idea, the rest of the villagers would taunt him for the rest of his life for usurping another man's position. Even the generations after him will suffer for it. Esiaga knew his request was wrong, and several things were at stake. Agana had a duty towards his father. He must go back and recover his father's land from his kinsmen. Esiaga's proposal was preposterous, to say the least.

Chapter 16

At Achara, something strange was happening. Akukwe, Egesi, and Orji were sick, and nobody could fathom the cause of their ill health. It all started with a tiny swell on the right hand. Akukwe, Egesi, and Orji went to the annexed farmland with their children to harvest the first batch of yams after ten months of planting, as was the practice in the village. They all came back with the same strange ailment.

Akukwe went to the farm with his wife and three sons. As he started to dig, he noticed a slight swelling on his right arm. he rubbed it and continued digging, before the sun was up, he noticed that both arms had swollen up and were aching badly. He tried to exercise both arms but could not lift them above the shoulders. Within a short while, he could no longer move both arms. Akukwe sat down on a mound and called out to his wife and sons to help him sit down. As they were helping him to sit, one of his sons noticed another swell on his right leg. He instructed his wife and children to leave the few yam tubers on the farm and take him home. By the time they got home, Akukwe could neither move his arms nor legs. His wife and children settled him on the bamboo bed in his Obu.

Before the end of that day, the news spread throughout the village that the same fate had befallen all three men in the three farmlands. Akukwe, Egesi, and Orji became bedridden in one day. The villagers now knew that Eke's swollen tummy was not an ordinary sickness either.

Three months earlier, Eke went to the Ude one early morning to tap palmwine, the first since he took over the Ude. The buyers were already waiting for him at his house. Eke brought down the gourds and took a sip from one of them, and shook his head in appreciation. The wine was sweet. He would add more money to the price he had already told the buyers. He brought down the gourds and set out for home. As he started up the gentle incline up the road from the Ude, he tripped and fell, and the palm wine poured away. Eke went home with empty gourds and an aching stomach. Within five days, Eke's stomach was swollen, and for the past three months, different medicine men had prescribed different medications for him without any improvement in his condition.

The Ege family suspected, it was a strange disease, but nobody said anything. With the news of Akukwe and the two other men, they could no longer bury their heads in the sand. Nweke quickly sent two of his sons to go and call the elders of the Ege family. Something had to be done and fast.

By twilight, they all gathered in Nweke's Obu. Nweke stood up to speak. He noticed the absence of several of his kinsmen. Those who had opposed the plan to take over Oluoha's farmlands did not come to answer the call except Eru, and he knew he was there for a reason.

"Ege family, kwenu, kwenu, kwuezuenu."

"Iya." Some of them answered. The response was lukewarm.

"We shouldn't let our knees start shaking because of the news of our brothers' sickness. Our cause is a just cause. My father told me the farmlands belong to our family. We took back what belongs to us. From what has happened, we know Oluoha kept something in the farmlands.

All we have to do is call a strong medicine man to remove it. Our brothers will get well. I have called you here together so we can decide which medicine man we will go for.”

“Ege family kwenu.” Akpa stood up to speak, he did not wait for a response to his greeting. “Anything we must do we should begin to do it as early as tomorrow morning. I agree with Nweke, the farmlands are ours. This is just a temporary scare. We will see the end of it. The medicine men from Etiti are good. We will go and invite one tomorrow.” Eru stood up, he did not care to greet his kinsmen.

“Are you not being optimistic for nothing? Eke has been sick for three months, and no medicine man has been able to help him. You all know what to do: give back Oluoha’s sons what belongs to them, and have this settled while there is still time to make amends.”

“Have you finished”? Nweke asked him.

“Yes, that is all I have to say.”

“From today, Eru, you are no longer welcome to the gathering of the Ege family until you are told otherwise. “Ege family, do I speak your mind?”

“Yes,” a few answered while a majority of the men remained silent.

“Nweke, you have no right whatsoever to stop me from attending the family meetings, but I will leave anyway. I have said all I came here to say.”

Eru got up and took his stool. It was about time he stopped showing up amid greedy men anyway. He had told them the right thing to do, and that was enough.

Early the next morning, the three men who were selected set out to go and call Anyanmuo, the medicine man from Etiti. His fame and the

potency of his drugs were known far and wide all over the community.

Chapter 17

“Agana, my brother, the village is tingling! Nnanyi has struck them.” Ekeoma was in high spirits. “Nne told me that Nnanyi would strike, and he has.”

They were seated in Esiagas Obu. Esiaga sat with the usual strange smile and glint in his eyes. It was the best news he had heard in a long while. He had waited these past few months for this news. During the farming season, he had wondered if the ‘Orami’ from the medicine man from Ukwa was impotent. He was the one who suggested the idea to Oluoha. He was the one, who brought the medicine man, and both had placed the Orami in all the choice farmlands together. Oluoha did not accompany them, but he was privy to the plan. He knew the lands his kinsmen would want first, and he was right on target. There was one Ude left, but Esiaga did not want to tell the young men seated with him. He did not want them to know he had anything to do with what was happening. The men who were sick were going to suffer for a long time before they died. He only wished Nweke were among those on the sick bed. The fox had used his kinsmen as guinea pigs. At least the issue was settled; none of them would dare enter the farmlands again.

“I told them that Oluoha will not die with his two eyes closed. Now they have seen it, they will pay the price.” Esiaga said, still with a smile on his face.

Agana sat there, without saying a word. He did not know whether to be happy, because they had been avenged or to be sad for his uncles who were bedridden. He would have felt differently if Nweke and Akpa

were the ones suffering. He also knew that the unfolding events would bring further complications and consequences.

“Agana, I can see you are neither happy nor sad about the news. What’s the problem?”

Agana did not answer.

“With the realization of their mistake, our kinsmen will reconsider their decision and give us back our lands. They will apologize to you and ask you to return.”

“Unfortunately, Eke, I do not see that happening anytime soon, if ever. You don’t know how far Nweke would go. The greed that will make a man want to kill his nephew does not disappear with the twinkling of an eye.”

“Even with four men on their deathbeds”

“He is ready to sacrifice more. He persuaded most of them, except a few, to agree to his plan in the first place. It is too early to predict my return.”

Esiaga looked at Agana and marvelled at his wisdom. How he wished Nwanna were half as perceptive as Agana. He had tried to convince Agana both in word and deed that he could live in his house forever if he chose, but Agana would not accept that. Lately, he had seen Agana’s budding interest in his first daughter, Akunma. He would encourage the romance and wait and see. If Agana marries Akunma, at least, that will ensure that he will show interest in what happens in his family. That would also mean Nwanna would have somebody to supervise him and cover his lack of drive.

“What about our in-laws from Obizi? Has the marriage date been set?”

“Yes, the marriage will take place next Nkwo day. It’s a pity you will not be able to attend. Ada will miss your presence.”

“Ensure that our in-laws are given all that is due to them. You know how it goes, some of our uncles might want to short-change them and make us look bad in their eyes. Be sure that doesn’t happen.”

“I will, we are still considering which date to set for Atuma’s marriage. Nne said we should give her a little time to rest after Ada’s marriage before she goes through the stress of organizing another marriage ceremony.”

“Let it be in the next three market days. Three weeks is enough for her to rest.”

“Atuma will be incredibly happy to hear that. She can’t wait for her marriage ceremony. She would have loved it to be the same day as Ada’s.”

“I can imagine how it feels, seeing how close they are.”

They chatted a little longer about their would-be in-laws, and Ekeoma got up to leave.

“Dede, I’m leaving.”

“Wait and have something to eat, I’m sure they are cooking something for you.”

“No, dede, I’ve had breakfast. I just wanted to come and tell Agana about the happenings in the village. We have a lot of work to do with the upcoming marriage ceremony.”

“Alright then, greet your mothers for me. I will come to the marriage ceremony.”

"I will, dede." Agana got up and saw his brother off at the entrance of the Obu. He was in no mood to go further

Anyanmuo, the medicine man, from Etiti shook his head again and groaned. He had done that several times as he examined Akukwe. He had seen the other sick men with the same ailment, and he was now in Akukwe's house. He knew that this was beyond him. He also knew that all three men would die eventually because this was no ordinary illness. All along, he was trying to make up his mind whether to tell the people who brought him the truth or if he should collect money from them, wait for a while, and later tell them he would not be able to cure the illness, as most medicine men did.

At last, Anyanmuo spoke up. "My brothers, did you tell me that these men went to their farm and came back with this strange illness?"

"Yes, they went to the family land, which we cultivate rotationally."

"Who owned the land before it became yours?"

"We have answered that question before, Anyanmuo."

"I know why I'm asking again. It is to make my point clear. Nweke, if you want your kinsmen to live, return the farmlands to the rightful owners."

"Anyanmuo, we are the rightful owners. Our late kinsman forcefully took it from one of our grand uncles, and we took back what is ours."

"If the lands belong to your extended family as you claimed, then your brothers won't be lying down sick."

Anyanmuo got up and put his paraphernalia in his raffia bag. He turned to the rest of the men in the room.

“This man and the rest will not get up from this bed unless you do the right thing and do it fast. It is Orami that struck them. Orami only strikes the guilty. They are guilty. You are guilty. If you decide to do the right thing within seven days, call me and I will come and perform the reconciliation ritual between you and the rightful owners. If you stay beyond seven days, these men will die.”

He stepped out of the room and left without looking back. The men in the room and the outer court sat in silence. Some exchanged glances. Nweke came out looking like a stung animal.

“The land belongs to us. What does he mean? Is he calling us liars or what? My father told me how Oluoha came to own the land. My father did not lie to me. We will bring another medicine man from Ngwa. They know about Orami more than the medicine men from Etit.”

“De Nweke, I would like to hear the whole story about that farmland if you don’t mind.” Akukwe’s eldest son spoke up this time. He had kept quiet all this time, but with all that had transpired these past few days, he realized that Nweke had used his father and the rest as guinea pigs. That realization came too late. Nweke ignored him. One after the other, the men left Akukwe’s house.

Chapter 18

“Are we going to help our husbands’ wife, Diadi, to cook for her daughter’s marriage?”

“Urunma, my sister, you know we should do so, but my husband warned me not to go and help.”

“So did my husband. I wonder why. What transpired between our husbands and their nephew should not concern us, their wives. After all, we did not join them in their wicked plot.”

“Lower your voice. As for me, I will sneak out when my husband is not watching, at least to go and see Ada’s husband, the man from Obizi. I heard he is very wealthy.”

“I heard that too, my sister. I wonder how my friend Diadi and her co-wife will cope.”

“Their friends from the other families are all there helping them with the cooking. I peeped into their compound this morning on my way to the stream.”

“You did? Maybe I should have done that, too. I hope Diadi won’t hold it against me. I am not her enemy; I will quickly go now and greet her and come out before my husband comes back.”

The marriage ceremony between Ada and the man from Obizi was about to begin. The women who were cooking were rounding up to get the compound ready for the marriage ceremony.

One week earlier, as was the tradition, Ada, her younger sisters and some of her friends had gone around the village with gifts of soap and salt, to inform everybody of the upcoming marriage. The bride-to-be

also used the opportunity to tell them where her husband comes from. On the day of the marriage, all those who received the gifts also came back with gifts for the bride.

Ada, already dressed in her second outfit for the day, sat in her room with her retinue of young women her age and some younger ones. They were singing and exchanging jokes at intervals. They were waiting for the bridegroom to arrive so that the singing would start in earnest. The young maidens were equally well dressed in their best attire, as this was an opportunity for them to find would-be husbands. Some of the men in the groom's entourage will also be looking out for young women to marry among the maidens.

In a short while, the bridegroom arrived with an entourage of singers and dancers. They sang and danced from the entrance of the village gate to their in-laws' house. Soon, the whole village gathered to witness the marriage and to eat and drink. The man from Obizi, as they called him, was a wealthy man from a reputable family, and the marriage ceremony would be worth witnessing.

The groom, his friends, and his family wore white shirts atop the traditional wrapper which was the current trend. Only the rich, so far, could afford the shirts. They looked resplendent as they sat around the Obi with their walking sticks.

The kolanuts were blessed and passed around, signifying the beginning of the marriage rites. This was followed by food and drinks. Both the in-laws and Amachara people were served food, while everybody waited for the 'showing of the bride.'

As Ada stepped out of the maiden's room with a cup of palwine in her hand and her retinue of young women, everybody cheered. She

looked beautiful in her purple velvet wrapper, which she tied a little above her bosom. Pink-coloured beads adorned her ears and neck. Her palms and the soles of her feet shone. Everyone could see the end product of the camwood dye on her body. For the past month, she had been indoors, eating and being groomed by the older women. During ‘mgbede’, the elderly women used the period to teach the bride-to-be how to look after her husband and how to care for her children, as soon as she has them, and how to relate to her in-laws in her new home. For everyone who saw Ada step out into the marriage arena, her ‘mgbede’ was a time well spent.

Ada carried the wine in a wooden cup, looking for her husband among the young men seated. She deliberately looked at the wrong places first, going around the area and showing off herself as was the tradition. She finally ‘found’ her husband, who was seated somewhere among the spectators. With that, another wave of cheers rent the air.

Uhegwu stood up as Ada and the maidens danced to where he sat, amidst cheers. They stopped in front of Uhegwu, and Ada knelt to offer him the cup of wine. He took the cup from her and drank from it, signifying marital agreement. The bride and groom danced to where the elders of Amachara sat. Now the marriage proper could begin. The man who was mandated to speak addressed the couple.

“Adanna, is this the man you have chosen to be your husband?”

“Yes, dede.”

“Uhegwu, is this the woman you have chosen to be your wife?”

“Yes, dede.” The people cheered.

“You have both answered this question earlier during the pre-marriage rites, but I asked it again so that everybody will hear and be a witness.”

"We have heard," the crowd shouted.

"Adanna, our daughter, as we know her, is a good girl, disciplined and well-trained. We do not want to hear that you raised your hand against our daughter. If you do, you will answer to the young men of Amachara." He turned to the young people.

"Young men of Amachara, do I speak your mind?"

"Yes, dede."

"He dares not," added some voices.

"When you quarrel, settle it between yourselves. Nobody else needs to hear about it. That shows maturity. The quarrel you cannot settle between yourselves, you can invite us to investigate it. But we do not wish to hear about such quarrels."

"Uhegwu, pick up that yam on the ground and give it to your wife."

He took the yam and gave it to Ada.

"This tuber of yam represents fertility. Adanna, as you receive the yam from your husband, we declare that you shall be a mother to many children."

"We agree, so shall it be," the crowd said in unison.

"In a year, we shall come and celebrate the birth of a new baby."

"We agree, so shall it be," the crowd responded.

"Our chi shall be with you. Go in peace. We all wish you well."

At the end of the blessing, the marriage gifts were brought out, and the bride and groom set out for Obizi, which was an hour's walk from Amachara. The singers were in front, and the bride and groom were in the middle, flanked by friends and family of the groom. With the full moon shining bright above them, they walked all the way to Obizi, where another reception ceremony awaited them.

Nweke engineered his kinsmen not to heed the advice of Anyanmuo. They brought several other medicine men to no avail. After two months, the conditions of the men became worse, their stomachs kept on swelling until they became the 'living dead'. As each week passed, Nweke's supporters became fewer and fewer; guilt and shame could not let them continue the charade of being rightful owners of Oluoha's farmlands. Soon, nobody showed much interest in the dying men except for perfunctory visits to their households. Six months later, Akuwe died, followed by Eke, Orji, and Egesi within days of each other. There was no mourning for them since everyone had long realized and accepted that they would die. It had taken too long.

Nweke's popularity and influence over his kinsmen died with the men struck by Orami. They no longer heeded his calls for family meetings, and when they did, it ended with arguments. His kinsmen's respect tilted towards Eru for standing up for the truth and taking the reproach that went with the stance. Nweke became bitter and reclusive.

Nobody dared enter Oluoha's farmlands or Ude anymore. Neither did they release the land to Agana or Ekeoma. Nweke resorted to using his position as the family head to settle scores with errant kinsmen. He also knew that his position as the head would soon come to an end, and he started looking for an alternative means of holding and wielding power.

Six years from the day he ran to Esiaga's house, Agana married Esiaga's first daughter, Akunma. The marriage ceremony did not attract much

fanfare, as both were living in the same compound. Esiaga tried to make it an event, but could not carry it off, and Agana was not interested in an elaborate ceremony.

PART 2

Chapter 19

“Agana gudu morni.”

“Gudu morni Chidi.” They both burst out laughing as they experimented with the new greeting that was spreading in Ohuru.

“You are up early today, and why are you dressed up like you are going to a festival?”

“I am going to attend the white man’s meeting. I told you about it the last time I was here. Since you don’t want to come along, I’m going with my cousin Chuka.”

“You mean you are going all the way to Okaji to attend a gathering of weaklings.”

“It is called chorch, and it is not a gathering of weaklings. I have been there three times before, remember? And I am not a weakling.”

“That is why I’m amazed. What do you find interesting in this new phenomenon?”

“Come with me and you will find out.”

“I will not come until you tell me what is so interesting in this eh eh, what did you call it?”

“Chorch, the white man said that there is an Almighty God who is higher than all the gods we know, and I believe him.”

“Of course, everybody believes that Amadioha is more powerful than every other god. What is new about that?”

“It is not Amadioha I’m talking about, Agana, come with me and listen and hear what the man is teaching us. Have you not heard how other

white men in other clans have defied Amadioha and other gods, and nothing happened to them?"

"Maybe he is waiting for the right time, and he will start killing them one after the other."

"He has waited too long already."

"Don't let the gods hear you say that, Chidi."

"Agana, do you know the most interesting thing in it for me? They are teaching us how to read and write."

"How to read and write what?"

"You can write your name on paper and read it. Other people can also write and read it. Not just your name, but a whole sentence. You can write this conversation we are having now and read it out later. Other people who joined the white men earlier are doing it. Do you know that there are people who can understand the white man's language and speak it? Though the white man sounds different because he speaks through his nose."

"Chidi, this is the story to tell the birds, you are telling me all these to convince me to go with you."

"Agana, just come with me this once and find out for yourself."

"Okaji is too far to go to confirm a rumour," Agana replied and started back to his room. Chidi hesitated, not willing to give up.

"How long will your wife and son stay with your mother?"

"They will be back next tomorrow."

"That means you will be alone for the next two days, it's a good time for you to come and see the white man's gathering for yourself."

"Ah, Chidi, you are so insistent. What has the white man done to you?"

"Come and find out for yourself, Agana."

“Alright, I will go with you this once because I don’t have anything to do today.”

Agana went inside the room to dress up. Chidi smiled in delight. Going to church would be much more interesting with his best friend in attendance. He prayed that Agana would be convinced to go again.

The road to Okaji was a mix of narrow track roads and wide communal roads that linked one clan to the other. The route traversed five clans from Ohuru to Okaji. Agana and Chidi walked side by side in brisk steps where the paths were wide enough, but when the paths narrowed, Chidi led the way. They kept the conversation going all the way to the church. Chidi was happy that he had company; he had been making these trips alone for the past three Sundays, and having company made it a lot more enjoyable.

“How was your last visit to Atuma and your in-laws? I hope her sons will have another younger one soon?”

“Didn’t I tell you?”

“Tell me what?”

“Didn’t I tell you Atuma gave birth to a girl two weeks ago?”

“Eh! What? You didn’t tell me? How could you forget to tell me such great news?”

“I’m sorry, Chidi, my brother, I thought I did.”

“That is good news.”

“Yes.”

“How about Ada? What is she doing about her situation?”

“You mean not having a child yet.”

“Yes.”

“Her husband will decide what he wants to do about that, not me.”

“I heard her pottery business is expanding.”

“Yes, she makes the finest pottery in the markets, and she is training other girls in pottery making.”

“My wife bought superbly refined ‘oku’ from the market the other day, and the seller told her she gets her stock from Obizi. I guessed it must be from Ada.”

“You guessed right; many women get their supplies from her.”

“That means she will soon be as wealthy as her husband.”

“You said so. Enough about my sisters, now tell me how you got to know about this chorchu you are bringing me to.”

“Yes, I will do that at the end of the service. We are almost there.”

Chapter 20

“Good morning, Omahia,” Reverend Raymond Wenger greeted the daylight as he opened his window to let in the morning air and sun. He had been doing this every morning for the past three years since he arrived in Omahia, and he was yet to get a reply. Reverend Wenger smiled at the brightness of the morning. He loved the beginning of every day. Each new day was a blessing. Each new day brought him joy in the service of God. The man looking out the window was tall and auburn-haired. His shiny brown eyes always had a hint of a smile, even this morning. Raymond, the white Methodist missionary has spent five years in the east of the Niger. From the day he decided to go on missionary work to Africa, he has not looked back. Despite the challenges and the sad events that had taken place, he was not discouraged, and his enthusiasm for the work of God grew instead of diminishing.

“Good morning, darling,” he greeted his wife, Ruth, with a broad smile as he turned away from the window.

“Good morning, Ray,” Ruth replied without a trace of a smile.

“It’s a beautiful day out there. God will do some marvelous things today; I can feel it.”

Ruth remained silent, staring at the roof from where she lay on the bed. Ruth has not always been like this. Raymond hoped and prayed that she would one day again become the vivacious humorous lady he married.

In a few weeks, members of his church will start raising a structure for church services. The head of the village has approved that they can build a church in the open space where they have been meeting for the

last three years. His congregation was growing, and the word of God was spreading. That was enough. His work in Africa and eastern Nigeria has been successful. The suffering and his losses had not been in vain. In two days, he would go and see the head of the Ukata family, that too was a breakthrough. He had been trying to share the word of God with the notable men in Okaji but had been rebuffed again and again. But two days ago, a member of his parish came with the great news that Mazi Ukata has consented to give him an audience. Great doors are opening to the gospel of Jesus Christ indeed. Ukata was a respected man in the community, and if he joined the church, he would influence a good number of other people to come too. He spent part of the night praying and studying the sermon he would preach at the church for the day. Reverend Raymond took his soap and sponge and walked towards the bathroom to bathe and get ready for the church service.

Ruth got up from the bed and went to the kitchen to make a cup of tea for her husband, her blonde hair still tussled from sleep. She did not bother to comb it. Her blue eyes took in her surroundings without much interest. She walked into the small hut and stood for a moment looking around the tiny kitchen. The wooden ladle and spoons hung on a wooden rail fastened to the wall with nails. Bowls and spoons were kept in a basket on the bare floor. A table made of bamboo and two bamboo chairs beside it served as their dining area.

Chioma was outside making a fire to boil water. She was grateful for her help. Making fire had been a task she hated to do in all the places they had lived since arriving in Africa. She had been eager and happy to learn and live like the people they saw in the African communities, but

the joy had gone when their son died. As a Christian and a missionary, she desperately wanted to get over the death of her son, but each day it became increasingly difficult. She knew it was not only the death of Mark but also that of their twin daughters that kept robbing her of the joy of their work. A year after Mark died, they rescued a set of twin girls whose parents threw away because having twins was taboo in that part of the country. Ruth had gladly gone out that night into the forest with Raymond to rescue the girls. She thought the discovery of the girls was compensation from God for the son she had lost. But a few days later, the girls died from pneumonia. They had stayed too long in the cold before being rescued. From that day on, a lump of sadness occupied the space where joy had been in Ruth's heart, and nothing had been able to move it, not even her husband's fervent prayers.

Ruth looked around the kitchen one more time. She walked out and stood in the open space in front of the house. The house was located a little distance from their church. It comprised a two-room mud house built on a straight line. The bedroom had a connecting door to the living room and another door that led to the kitchen. The bathroom and toilet were built some meters further down the bush path, away from the living area.

They lived two miles away from the rest of the villagers, and the only company they had was different species of birds in their nests on the many trees that surrounded them. A few of their parishioners came to visit occasionally, but the communication barrier and her demeanour usually scared them off. They could not understand why she always looked unsmiling while her husband was warm and amiable. Only Chioma remained faithful in coming to spend some time with her. That

morning, as Ruth stood watching Chioma, she decided, something had to give. She had mourned long enough.

Chapter 21

The “Church” in Okaji village was a space under a large tree called Achi. The big tree has many thick branches that provide enough shade. The tree was believed to be older than everybody in the village, and the superstition has it that if it were cut down, the village would be covered with water.

Unlike other communities where white missionaries were treated with hostility, the people of Okaji regarded them largely with indifference. They have heard stories of what befell others who opposed the missionaries from entering their communities, how neither the gods nor the spirit of the dead in the evil forest has so far been able to drive the missionaries out. When the missionaries came into Okaji and asked the elders where they could build their church, they told them they could stay in the evil forest near the Achi tree, which was on the outskirts of the village. For the past three years, Reverend Raymond had repeatedly asked for a permanent place to build a church, and the elders had refused to grant his request until two months ago.

It took five months of praying, fasting, and evangelism before he got the first convert, an elderly widow who told them she had a dream, and someone in the dream told her to go to the gathering under the Achi tree. From then onwards, she became their mouthpiece in the village, and through her, several people came to join the church. A few came from Okaji, and some others from neighbouring villages.

Agana and Chidi arrived at the church as Reverend Raymond was saying the opening prayer, and the interpreter interpreted the prayer in

the Igbo language. Eight bamboo benches were arranged in four rows, eight people were seated in the first and second rows, while the others had a scattering of two or three people. Agana and his friend headed to the bench on the last row.

“Why are there so few people in the chorchí? I thought that half of the population of Okaji attended the church.”

“Close your eyes and don’t be so loud,” Chidi whispered to Agana.

“I will not close my eyes; I need to see what is going on here.”

Agana took in his surroundings; a few of the young men wore shirts and shorts like the interpreter, while others had the traditional wrapper tied to their waists. They were barefooted like him, only the white man, his wife, and the interpreter had shoes on. Agana stared at the white man and his wife, fascinated. They looked so fair; their skin was almost white. It was the first time he saw people who were fairer than him. He heard about white missionaries but never paid attention to the stories until his friend started attending their church and kept inviting him to come.

The deserted track road they took to the church was the only link between the church and Okaji, and it was quite some distance away. The church looked like a setting in the middle of nowhere. He saw another track road behind the white man.

Chidi sat down as the prayer ended. Agana, who was lost in thought, did not hear anything that was said.

“Is this not an evil forest?”

“It used to be an evil forest. The Okaji people didn’t want to have anything to do with the white man and his religion, but they were afraid of being attacked, so they gave them this land to build their church.”

"You brought me to an evil forest; don't you know that the spirit of the dead will be angry at us?"

"The spirits will not do anything to us. This church has been here for three years, and the spirits have not killed anyone yet."

"That doesn't mean they won't kill them."

"Relax, my friend, and let us listen to the Revirendi."

"What did you call him?"

"Revirendi."

"Is that his name?"

"I don't know, that's what everyone calls him."

"Revirendi." Agana tried to mimic his friend.

Two other young men came and sat with them at the back.

"If today is the first time you're coming to our church, you should wait after the service, the Reverend would like to see you and get to know your names."

"Why does the interpreter say things that are not true? I did not see the Revirendi talk to him."

"He is not lying, he says that every Sunday, the white man must have instructed him to make the announcement, maybe long before I joined the church."

"I will not wait; I don't want to be bewitched by the white man as you have been."

"Nobody bewitched me. You see those two young men at the front row, they were known criminals in Okaji, but now they don't steal from people's farms anymore."

"I see."

“The short one sitting beside them is the first son of Ezemuo, the gods chose him to succeed his father, he refused and ran away to Okaji to join the white man’s church.”

“So, it is a gathering of the rejects you brought me to. Is it because I ran away from my uncles that makes you think I belong here?”

“Stop it, Agana, I’m here too, am I a thief or did I run away? I believe that the religion of the white man is true because Amadioha or the other gods have not killed them.

“It is still a matter of time.”

“Sh sh, the white man is about to tell us about his God, let us listen and hear what he has to say.”

“Our reading today is taken from the book of Matthew, chapter one; we will read the whole chapter,” Reverend Raymond began his sermon.

“When did the interpreter learn the white man’s language?”

“I don’t know, let us listen.”

Agana listened to the story the white man told them about God and his son Jesus. It agreed with his traditional concept of God, the difference was that the god he knew did not have any sons; he only had other smaller gods, who did his bidding. Well, if they said their own God had a son, maybe he does. The role of Mary in the whole story was beyond him. The concept of a virgin giving birth to a God was way over his head. If other people believed it, and if the white man believed it enough to leave his country to come and tell them about it, then maybe some parts of the story must be true.

At the end of the sermon, the white man told them that whoever believed in Jesus, the son of God, would be saved and live forever with

God. That, too, agreed with Agana's traditional belief that when people die, they go to another place where they stay and watch over their children for generations. If he could also see his chi face to face, he had some questions he would ask him.

At the end of the sermon, Reverend Raymond asked if anyone would want to be saved.

"If you believe that Jesus is the son of God and you want to be saved, raise your hand."

He waited, but nobody did. Four new people came to church that day. He smiled to himself; he knew they would be converted eventually. It took him one full year to bring five people to salvation. He has been schooled in patience.

"We would start building a house we can call church starting next week, we would like everyone to volunteer in the building."

The old members of the church started clapping. It was great news. Chima stood up clapping louder than the rest of the members, others joined him. At last, he would feel secure inside a building, he has been in perpetual fear of being attacked and abducted by his kinsmen in the open arena.

"Will you come and help us, Agana?" Chidi asked as he sat down.

"I will think about it. Who is that man who stood up first?"

"His name is Chima, he is the one who refused to serve Ezenmuo."

The Reverend continued his announcement.

"We shall be going out on evangelism next week. Anyone who wants to join us can come along. Is anyone willing to join us?"

He waited for a response.

Nobody raised his or her hand, and no one indicated interest in going along; they did not want the jeers or wrath of the community. Anna, the only faithful member who sometimes went with them on evangelism, did not raise her hand either. Raymond would find out the reason at the end of the service.

Chapter 22

Chima, if you continue the way you are tying that rope to the wood, we will sleep here today. Both of you should come down from there and let the men do the work."

"Where did you learn to tie the roof? You are doing it like a novice. Come down, let me teach you how to do that fast."

"Ejike, all you do is talk. What have you done since this work started?"

"His job is to make everyone laugh. That is all he is good at."

"Keep quiet, Chuma, both of us are in the same boat. How many times did you fall off the mud while we were mixing it? Anybody would have thought there was slime on your feet."

"Agana, am I not tying this rope well?"

"You are, Chima, it's just that you are slow, come down and let me do it. You can stand on the ladder and watch me."

"Agana, you know how to do everything in this business. You must have been a paid labourer in your village. I don't believe this story about your family. I'm sure you were a paid labourer; how much were they paying you for this kind of job at Amachara?"

"You are a jester, Chuma. Where I come from, every young man can build a house all by himself. We are hardworking people."

"I hear you. Are you trying to say, we are lazy?"

"Not we, Chuma, he means that you are lazy." Chidi countered.

"I didn't say anyone is lazy. Chuma is a good craftsman, he will show his expertise when we get to the stage that he is good at."

"When the building is finished, I guess."

All of them laughed.

Agana has been attending the church for the past month and had volunteered to work on the church building just like the rest of the young men in the church.

“Catechism is ending soon, and we will all get baptized. Agana, have you decided on the baptismal name to take?” Chima asked.

“I am thinking about it. Have you decided on a name?”

“Yes, I am changing my name to Joseph.”

“What about you, Chidi?”

“I think I like John.”

“I thought you would have chosen Isaiah since you have always paraded yourself as a prophet.”

“Maybe you will start seeing visions for real,” Ejike added with a laugh.

“What about you, Ejike, which baptismal name are you taking?”

“My baptismal name will be Ejike. Nobody is changing my name to anything else. It is our children who should take on new names as they get baptized, not us.”

“You know what I think. I will fuse my name with one from the bible and get a new name.”

“Like what?”

“Since there are names like Isaiah, Obadiah, and Jeremiah, I can change my own to Aganamiah.”

“Yes, and mine can become Ejizikiel.”

They all burst out laughing.

“I don’t think we should be joking about things like that.”

“Ehe, apostle John, don’t tell me it is a sin to think aloud of what we want to do with our names.”

“Be serious, Agana, which baptismal name will you choose?”

“It is the name my father gave me, Iroaganachi, Agana, for short. I am not changing my name.”

“Gbam, I agree with you, my friend. We are on the same page.” Ejike said gleefully. “Our names are good enough.”

“Nobody said our names are not good enough.”

“Then why do you want to change it?”

“I think I will keep my name, Chidi, and add John as a second name.”

“I am changing my name to Joseph,” Chima said with finality.

Reverend Raymond and his wife walked to the building site and were greeted with a chorus of “Gudu morni sah,” to which he replied with a smile. The interpreter jumped to his feet from where he lay dozing in the early morning sun.

“Tell the young man on the roof that I appreciate his work. It hasn’t been long since he joined us, and he has been of great help.”

The interpreter did so, and Agana acknowledged the compliment with a nod and a smile. He liked Reverend Raymond and his wife. She was beautiful, though she rarely smiled.

Reverend Raymond was pleasantly surprised when Ruth told him she would accompany him to Mazi Ukata’s house. For the past few weeks, she has started to take an interest in life and the mission again. God is indeed opening great doors, big and small. They stopped by the church site to encourage the builders.

They watched as Agana looped the rope and tied it up in quick succession with both hands. He certainly was good at what he did. They inspected the rest of the structure and left for Mazi Ukata’s house with the interpreter

The day was Orie market day, and the market was in full swing. It was a perfect day to take that route to Ukata's house. Just going through the village square and being seen by members of the community and traders from different clans was evangelism all by itself. It would serve as a reminder of the new religion to all the people. The people stared at them as they walked by. They were still objects of interest three years after they arrived in the Okaji community.

"A good number of the people here are light-skinned. What do you think? Fairer than all the people we've seen since we came to Africa."

"Yes, they are."

"But Agana looks fairer than all of them and almost taller. Have you tried to find out where he comes from?"

"I have heard some stories about him. But I will ask him about his family after worship next Sunday."

"Do so. I would like to meet the rest of his family."

"I will, my dear."

Raymond was happy that his wife was interested in something and somebody after all these months. It has been a long while since she took any notice of anybody.

"Why don't we buy a few things from the market? I would like to use it as an opportunity to talk to some of the women."

"We will do that on our way back. We can't carry a bag to Ukata's house. He might think we brought him a gift."

"That's alright. We will buy a few things on our way back."

Ruth smiled and waved at the women as they walked by. Some returned the gesture, some did not. She was determined to be friendly to as many people as she could.

Chapter 23

“Agana, have you noticed that the Revirend likes you?”

“Does he?”

“Yes, I think so.”

“Why do you think he likes me?”

“He always smiles broadly anytime he talks to you. Maybe it’s because you look like him.”

“Chidi you are as light skinned as I am and since I have known the white man, he smiles broadly at everyone.”

“Anyway, Agana, I want you to tell the white man your story and see if he can intervene and compel your kinsmen to allow you to go back to your family.”

“I don’t think he can help me, but thank you for suggesting that.”

“Agana, our elders say that if a person falls into the ditch and raises his hand, a passer-by will see it and help him. If he does not raise his hands, help might not come. There is no harm in asking.”

“Since you have known the white man longer than I have, why don’t you tell him about me?”

“That is a good idea, we will ask the interpreter if he can help us.”

“The interpreter? Have you not heard how he would tell the parishioners to buy a goat or a chicken for him anytime they want to ask for assistance from the white man?”

“I have, we can afford to give him anything he wants as long as he does our bidding.”

“No, we will not, we will have to find a way or situation where he will be forced to help us without embellishing what the white man says for his benefit.”

Agana and Chidi waited until all the other parishioners left the church. They did not know why the white man asked them to stay behind and see him after church service. They were happy they did not have to go through the interpreter to meet with the Reverend, after all. Agana was excited that the Reverend wanted to see them. Reverend Raymond spoke through his nose, and Agana never understood anything he said. It was only the interpreter who did. He looked around quickly for the interpreter and saw him at the far end of the church.

“Agana.”

Agana looked up in surprise to see Reverend Raymond standing beside the bench, smiling, he must have been too anxious and lost in his thought.

“Gudu morni sah.” Agana jumped up from the bench.

“Agana, it is good morning, Reverend,” the interpreter corrected him.

“Good morning, Agana,” Reverend Raymond replied, still smiling. Agana always intrigued Reverend Raymond. He looked fairer and taller than most people in the church, just as his wife had observed.

“Agana, I heard you ran away from your village. What happened?”

Agana relayed his story through the interpreter.

“Agana was shocked and excited at the same time. Was it a coincidence or an act of God? He has been mulling over how to reach the Reverend

and ask him for help, and now the Reverend is asking him about his family.

“Do you want to go back to your village?”

“Yes, sah, but my uncles will still want to harm me if I go back.”

“When would you like to go back to Amachara?”

Agana looked at the white man in surprise. Could he really help him go back? He looked at Chidi, not knowing what to answer.

Reverend Raymond repeated the question.

“As soon as possible, I will go back tomorrow if it is possible”.

“You cannot go back tomorrow, there are things that need to be arranged, but I assure you that you will go back, and nobody will touch you.”

“Tanki sah, tanki, sah.” Agana was elated. He could not believe this was happening.

“You two can go now. Agana I will do something about your case soon, I promise. Invite your guardian to church next Sunday, will you?”

“I will sah, tanki sah.”

Agana and Chidi left the Reverend and interpreter and hurried back home. He would have galloped home with joy if he were younger. It had been ten years since he escaped from death. Now he was married with two sons. His second son was born four months back.

“You see that coming to church with me is going to benefit you.”

“Yes, my friend, who would have thought that joining the white man’s church would change my life? I hope he will do as he has promised.”

“I believe he will do as he has said.”

Agana told his wife about his conversation with the white man as soon as he got home. He did not tell Esiaga because he feared he might scuttle his chances of going back to Amachara if he knew how. Esiaga still nursed the hope that Agana would live in Ohuru for the rest of his life.

Chapter 24

The District Commissioner in charge of Omahia summoned Nweke, the warrant chief of Amachara, to his office and asked him to sit down. Nweke became nervous and fidgety. The Commissioner, as he heard, was genial towards the warrant chiefs, but the man sitting across the table looked grim and angry. He wondered what he had done wrong. He always tried to do the white men's bidding. He went the extra mile to increase his popularity at the district office in charge of his community, even when it meant getting into conflict with everyone else. The only thing that mattered to him was his position as a warrant chief and the perks that came with it.

Nweke had no contact with the district commissioner, as a warrant chief, he reported to the district head. The warrant chiefs rarely had meetings with the heads of the districts unless there was a conflict to be resolved. So, when he was summoned by the district commissioner, he felt uneasy. Sitting across the table from the district commissioner, his unease increased. He had tried earlier to find out from the interpreter the reason for his summons, but the clerk, as he was referred to, had no clue.

"Do you know anybody called Agana Oluoha?" The Commissioner asked him. Nweke was startled and only stared at him. How did he know Agana?

"Answer the white man." The interpreter ordered Nweke.

"Yes, sah, I know him, he is my kinsman."

"Where is he now?"

"I don't know exactly; he is somewhere near our community."

"Why is he not living in your village?"

"He committed a sacrilege and was to be offered as a sacrifice to appease the gods and the aggrieved people, but he ran away."

"What exactly did he do?" Nweke told the story with heavy distortions to make it look right.

After his narrative, the Commissioner simply told him that Agana was returning to the village in four weeks and would be under the protection of the Queen of England, represented in Nigeria by the British government. He warned Nweke that he would be held responsible if any harm came to Agana.

Nweke came out of the Commissioner's office stunned and angry that Agana was coming back to Amachara. Agana, who had stripped him of dignity among his kinsmen. How did he know the Commissioner, and how did the Commissioner know about Agana? Questions whirled in his head.

That will not happen. He would find a way to turn the people against him. He would also ensure that whatever happened was not traced to him, though he was not sure how he would accomplish that.

A lot has happened in the last ten years. There have been lots of changes in the practices and beliefs. Many people have accepted the new religion, though not wholeheartedly. Most of them in the church still consulted the traditional medicine men and still offered libations to the gods, and joined in all the traditional practices. It would be difficult to convince the people of Umuako to harm Agana. Besides, his popularity among his kinsmen was almost non-existent. The other families in the village never gave their consent to the sacrifice in the first place. He

further became alienated from the rest of the community by becoming an informant to the white men. That was how he became a warrant chief in the first place. When the white men came to Omahia and opened an administrative office, they needed people in the communities who would give them information on the things that went on in the communities that made up the district to make their administration easier. Nweke saw that working for the white men would allow him to wield power and recover his lost honour among his kinsmen and the community. By aligning with the white men, he became alienated from everyone.

Nweke did the long walk home, a dejected man. He did not tell anybody about his conversation with the District Commissioner.

Four months after Reverend Raymond's first conversation with Agana, he called him to tell him that a date has been set for him to return to his village. He also told him that the Commissioner had ordered armed men to escort him back to his village to ensure that nobody tries to stop him.

Agana went home and told Esiaga of his date of departure, and Esiaga was incredulous.

"What did you say?" He shouted at Agana.

"Dede, I will go back to Amachara in two weeks' time. I wanted to tell you when I am quite sure."

"You intentionally did not want to tell me until about the time you are leaving. Do you think I did not hear about your dealings with the white man? You thought I would stop you from going back. You can go back to your village. You always wanted to go back. You can go back today if you want."

Agana expected the outburst, and Esiaga did not disappoint. He had become more eccentric as he got older, and reasoning with him was pointless. Agana went out of the Obu and entered his room.

Akunma was busy folding her children's clothes. They have been gradually putting their belongings together, not that there was much to pack. Agana had been frugal in buying household stuff. He hoped that one day he would go back to his village, and now it was about to happen.

He moved about in a daze. Could this be happening? What could have prompted Reverend Raymond to take such an interest in him? What could he ever give the Reverend to show his appreciation? He would think of something by the time he settles down in Amachara. He would come and thank the Reverend, no matter how long it took.

Chapter 25

On the day of their departure, Agana, his wife, and two sons set out for Amachara with ten armed white men. Five were in front while five were behind Agana and his entourage. The head of the team was Mr. Rogers. The whole village of Ohuru came out to see the white men. They have never seen such a sight before. For most of them, it was their first time seeing so many white men together, and the white men wore military uniforms. Their military regalia was a marvel to behold. Men, women, and children all stood staring at the men and the guns. Many of them offered to accompany Agana home just to be in the crowd. Some accompanied them to the boundary of the village and went back, while others went all the way to Amachara. They were driven by curiosity. They wanted to see what would happen when Agana got home, though they knew that no sane man would dare the white men with the guns.

“Dede, some white men are coming to kill all the men in our village,” Chituru told her uncle breathlessly. She had seen the white men and guns from the hill beyond the river that separated Uga and Amachara.

“It’s not possible, why would they fight us, we have not done anything to warrant that.” Her uncle replied, going out of his Obu. By the time he got outside, the story had gone around the village. Some men who were on the farm quickly ran home, while some decided to stay on the farm and see what will happen.

Everyone went back to his or her family, the men stood in front of their houses to watch." What is going on?" Urnma asked no one in particular.

"Some young men came back with the news that some white men were marching towards our village with guns. We are waiting to see what it is we have done wrong."

"I don't believe they are coming to fight. How can they fight us when they came to tell us about their God who loves everyone?"

"Haven't you heard what happened at Okigwe, how they killed those who opposed their entrance into their village? They came with guns and with religion."

"At least they opposed them, we have not opposed anybody."

Questions and answers were flying back and forth among the men.

Obohu River separated Amachara from Uga and other communities. The only bridge across the river was large trunks of trees placed side by side on top of each other. It was a tricky crossing. On getting to the river, the white men gave their guns to the natives, who carried them across while the white men swam across.

The people of Amachara usually crossed the bridge slowly. They would place one leg in front of the other and spread their hands sideways for balance. They did that when going across the river to attend formal occasions; at other times, they swam across. Most of the people of Amachara were good swimmers. The people who carried the guns did the hand-sideways crossing, with the guns placed firmly on their heads.

The escorts swam across the river and started the uphill trek to Amachara. By the time they got there, their clothes were dry.

As the entourage entered Achara, the older people recognized Agana and realized it was not an invasion. Nonetheless, nobody went near to welcome him. One glance at Mr. Rogers was enough to stall any impulse to run and hug Agana or his sons, who bore a striking resemblance to him.

Agana did not tell his family members about his return. He wanted it to be a surprise. He did that as a precaution, too. Mr. Rogers and his team stopped by the entrance to the Obu, and Agana walked into his father's compound. A whoop of joy swept over the compound, and the women and the girls let out an exclamation of victory. As his wife and children were ushered into the compound, Agana stood and looked around. Everything looked almost the same as they were when he left. There were no alterations except for the aging huts. Agana started the Amachara victory war dance. He made four short runs to the corners of the building and stopped abruptly in the middle, and brought down his right leg hard on the ground. Ekeoma and Chidi joined in the dance. The women let out a whoop of joy and started singing and dancing.

Shortly afterward, Rogers summoned the elders of the village through the interpreter. When they all gathered in the Obu, Rogers addressed them in a stern voice.

"We did not come to fight or hurt anybody in Amachara; rather, we brought back your son, who was unjustly sent away from this village ten years ago. We are here under the authority of the Queen of England to leave him in your hands. If any harm comes to him, we shall hold you

responsible. And I promise you, none of you shall be spared. Do you understand me?"

"We understand you."

"Who is Nweke?"

Nweke stood up, "Here I am."

"We have been informed of your role in this saga. You will remain a warrant chief because this happened a long time ago. We were ordered to tell you that, if you so much as utter a rude word to Agana, you will be stripped of the title and the authority that goes with it, and you will be imprisoned. Do you understand me?"

"Yes, sah," Nweke answered him.

"All of you can go now."

Mr. Rogers and his team bid Agana farewell and left. But the men from Ohuru, who came of their own free will, stayed back. They wanted to be served kola and drinks.

As soon as the white men left, the welcome party for Agana began. The men, women, and children of Amachara went in droves to welcome him back. Among his kinsmen, only Eru and his sons and three other uncles came; the rest stayed away. Some wanted to come but dared not because they were not to eat or drink in Agana's house until the traditional reconciliation rites were performed.

Agana settled in Amachara and started rebuilding his life and that of his family.

Chapter 26

Nine months later, Agana went with gifts to thank Reverend Raymond. The gift included three goats, three chickens, and twenty tubers of yam.

“Agana, welcome, sit down.”

“Thank i sah, thank i mah.”

“Are you having any problem with your kinsmen?”

“No, sah. I came especially to thank you. My people say that a chicken does not forget who plucked its feathers during the rainy season, so I have come to say thank you.”

“You are welcome, Agana, it is my pleasure. Are you still attending church?”

“No, sah, there is no church in Amachara yet. The nearest church is at Etit, about two hours away.”

“Really?”

“Yes, sah.”

“You can come to our church from your village, it’s not very far.”

“I will try, sah.”

Agana left after presenting his gifts to Raymond and his wife.

“Ray, I’ve been thinking about it, don’t you think it will be a good idea to open a branch of our mission at Amachara? Agana said they don’t have any churches close to his community.”

Ruth and her husband were seated outside on a bamboo chair under the tree in front of their house. The cool soothing breeze on their bare hands and feet provided respite from the hot African sun. Raymond was quiet for a few minutes.

“It would be difficult to acquire a property to build a church. Remember how long it took to get the elders to allow us to build here?”

“I think it would be a good idea to use the disputed land between Agana and his kinsmen to build a church.”

“Yes, that is a great idea. But wait a minute, other people in the community may not welcome us in their midst, you know, the elders in the community make decisions for everyone. It is not Agana’s decision to make.”

“There’s no harm in trying. We can visit Agana and see for ourselves if the people are friendly or hostile. I have a gut feeling it will work out well, we need to pray about it.”

“Yes, we will pray about it and seek God’s guidance.”

“If God directs us to go to Amachara, how can we get another missionary to come here?”

“You are getting ahead of God, Ruthie. We have not prayed yet, and you are thinking about our replacement. Be patient, we will cross that bridge when we get there.”

“We will get there, Ray, trust me. I know God is leading us to expand.”

“We will seek God’s confirmation.”

“We will.”

One year later, Raymond and Ruth were ready to relocate to Amachara. Members of their parish organized a farewell ceremony for them. The new missionary, John, and his wife were in attendance. The farewell ceremony started with a rendition of songs by the choir members, followed by bible recitations by a few church members. The main attraction of the day was the rendition by Anna Obi, the seventy-

year-old grandmother who was their first convert. Anna recited Mark chapter four, from verse one to the end.

"Wow, Ray, that is wonderful. Such good memory, and by an old woman."

"Yes, Anna is a wonder."

"How long has she been a member?"

"She has been with us for close to four years. She was our first convert in Okaji. She was among the first three members we got. She has played a major role in bringing others to Christ. I believe she will continue doing that, she is still quite strong."

"You have done an excellent job, Ray, judging from all we've seen and heard today."

"Thank you, John. More work needs to be done. The prominent men in the communities need to be converted. As we discussed, I have been preaching to a few of them. You need to continue until they are converted."

"Yes, I will, with God's help. How far is Amachara from here? I hope you will come and visit us regularly. Your old members would be encouraged by such a gesture."

"Of course, I will visit every fortnight. It's a short distance from here. It is about an hour's walk."

"And you call that a short distance?"

"Yes, John, once you walk it a few times, you no longer notice the distance?"

"I hope I will get used to the long walk."

"You will, John, you will."

Chapter 27

“Agana, are we not going to wait for the white man and his wife at their house before their arrival?”

“No, you will not go there today. You will stay at home and look after the children. I will go with Emenike, my friend.”

“I want to go with you and welcome them.”

“Not today, Akunma, please, I don’t want to start an argument.”

The frequent argument with Akunma, on just about every issue, was beginning to irritate him lately. She always wanted to have her way, which was unusual for women of her generation. Agana never heard his mother quarrel with his father. If she were aggrieved about something, she would come into her hut and murmur and complain and let out her frustration on her children. Agana has tried every male trick he knew to make Akunma more submissive without success. Maybe the presence of a second wife would be the solution to her stubbornness.

Agana heard his children greeting Emenike and hurried out to meet him outside.

“Eme, you are here already.”

“Yes, Agana, can we go now? I saw some people with loads on their heads a short distance from Obohu river, it must be the levland and his people.”

“Emenike it is not levland, it is Revirendi.”

“It sounds like a tongue twister. It will take a long time for me to learn.”

“I took a while learning how to pronounce it myself. Eme, I hope you will join the new church as soon as we start.”

"I will wait and see. Is it not on the land that killed Akukwe that you built the house for the white man? And that is where they will also build the church? If Orami does not strike them or any other person who attends the church, then I will join."

"Orami will not strike anyone, have you not heard stories from other lands where they gave white men evil forests to build their churches, expecting the evil spirits to drive them away, yet nothing happened to them?"

"Orami is different, it's a different situation here."

"The God whom the white men are serving is more powerful than Orami. You must believe me."

"Like I said, we will wait and see."

'Besides, they did not take the land by force; our elders consented to give it to them.'

As Reverend Raymond and Ruth walked to Amachara, Ruth was elated. She knew she would love living there, though she had only been there once with her husband. The people of Amachara were friendlier than the Okaji people. She knew that the church would record more attendance soon after they started. Also, the project she had planned to implement will keep her busy and involved with the women.

The expanse of land that was in dispute between Agana and his kinsmen was big enough to build whatever they wanted. What an irony that a piece of land in dispute would become a means to help them accomplish great things for the Lord.

For the past forty-five minutes, they have been walking, and they were beginning to feel cramps in their legs. Soon, they will get to the river, Obohu, where they will have to swim across to the other side and

climb the steep hill to Amachara. The swim will be a welcome relief from the hot sun. An advance party had left ahead of them with their luggage. A few of their parishioners from Okaji, who insisted on seeing them safely to their new post, were behind them.

As they arrived in Amachara, a welcome party was ready to welcome them and escort them to their new home.

“Welcome, sah.”

“Welcome, sah.” Emenike mimicked his friend.

“Thank you, Agana, are these your friends?”

“Yes, sah.”

“Welcome, missus.”

“Thank you, Agana. I hope your friends and their families will join the church as soon as we start.”

Agana did not respond.

Ruth walked into their new home and looked around. The rooms here were more spacious. There were about four rooms built in a straight line with connecting doors. At last, she could have a room to herself. The kitchen and storage space formed an L shape at one end of the room. Agana and his friends had gone the extra mile to make chairs and get the bamboo beds ready before Raymond and Ruth arrived. She still could not believe that they were able to acquire such a large piece of property so easily. When she and Raymond came to Amachara the first time, they asked Agana to show them the disputed land, and he did. Ruth chose the spot where the house was built. She recalled their meeting with the warrant chief and elders of the village and realized that their possession of the land was proof of God’s mercy and grace.

Raymond and Ruth were happy to come to Amachara without as much stress as they had experienced at the other communities where they had lived.

All they came with was their clothing and kitchen utensils. They left the chairs, beds, and other things for John and his wife. The chairs Agana provided will serve their purpose until the furniture they requested from their homeland mission office arrives. Ruth sat on top of her suitcase to rest her aching feet.

By the evening, the villagers came walking by to stare at the new arrivals. The men and women in the village slowly walked past the house to have a closer look at the white couple. The children stood and stared. Ruth waved to them, some waved back, while others just stared. She felt at ease, and for the first time in a long time, she was happy to be alive.

A few weeks later, Agana, Eminike, and a few others went to clear the site for the construction of a new church.

"When is the church starting?"

"Next Sunday, ten days from today."

"That soon?"

"Yes, at least between now and then, we will be able to erect a temporary structure for the Church."

"Will you come?"

Eminike ignored Agana.

"Eme, you have not answered my question. You will enjoy coming to church, especially the singing. You like singing, maybe you will become the lead singer in our church."

"What kind of songs do you sing? 'Nwaeru' or 'uko'?"

“No, it is nothing like that. We sing songs that praise God, like the song I tried to teach you three days ago.”

“I never learned the song, it was not interesting.”

“Don’t worry, you will like it when we sing it in church. There are other songs too.”

“Maybe, just maybe.”

Agana and Emenike have been doing chores for the white man and his wife for the past two weeks. Emenike was surprised at how amiable Reverend Raymond was. His only contact with white men was the day Mister Rogers and his team escorted Agana back, and because of what transpired that day, he perceived every white man to be as hostile as Mr. Rogers. Reverend Raymond was different. He would love to get to know him better, and he could only do so by joining the church. Yet, he will have to wait and see.

EPILOGUE

The members of the new church were seated in rows at the front. There were several empty seats. Agana, his wife, and two sons sat in the front row; his mother, stepmother, and siblings sat in the second row. The only people in attendance were Emenike, his wife, and four children who sat on the last bench at the back.

Nothing has happened to the white man and his wife since they moved into their house four months prior. The church was built close to the house, and nothing has happened. Emenike was persuaded that maybe the white man's Chi is stronger than their own. That was the reason he joined his friend to attend church. He hoped that his extended family would soon join them, as well as his other kinsmen.

Other curious villagers stood a little distance away, staring at the new phenomenon. Reverend Raymond gave a sermon that day from the first book of Mathew, just like he did the first time Agana attended church and in his other mission fields. It was the starting point for all new members.

Some distance away from the church, Agana and his friend, and some Church members from Okaji had cleared the site for a hospital. Ruth hoped it would be ready before the beds and medicines she requested from her home country arrived. For now, she was focused on making friends with the women and with as many villagers as she could. In a few months, she would also start a training school for women and young girls to teach them how to read and write. She would also

teach them the basics of the nursing profession. That way, they would be encouraged to come to church.

At the end of the church service, Ruth got back home and picked up her diary. She wrote down the date of the first church service they held in Amachara. It was the fourth day of May, nineteen hundred and twenty-nine

GLOSSARY OF WORDS

Aju:	Round padded clothing.
Aku:	Palm kernel
Chi :	God
Chorchi:	Church
Dede:	General name or title for elders.
Ekpete:	Drums. (Musical instrument)
Mbgede:	Traditional grooming for brides-to-be.
Mkpoko:	Bamboo bed.
Nwaeru:	A song/ dance performed during festivals.
Ngwo :	Palm wine.
Nku:	Firewood.
Nzu:	Chalky white mud.
Obu:	A sitting room built at the entrance of a home.
‘Oke:	The boundary of a property or place.
Okwa:	A kola nut bowl.
‘Oku’:	Pot or bowl made from pottery.
Ude:	Palm wine Orchard.
Ugba:	Oil bean tree or seed.
Uko:	A traditional dance for the New Yam Festival

ON THE TRAIL TO FREEDOM

Agana is a promising young man whose future is threatened by the greed and envy of some of his kinsmen. After the death of his father, he became a threat and a target to the men who plot to eliminate him. He is accused of manslaughter he did not commit and was to be killed as an appeasement to the gods. He will find out if his 'Chi' will save him from the plan of his kinsmen.

This novel is set in 19th century Igboland and the customs and traditions that shaped the daily lives of the characters involved, and how some finer aspects of these traditions influence the world view of the succeeding generations.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ihuoma Iroaganachi holds a Bachelor of Arts degree in English and Literary Studies from University of Calabar and a Master of Arts in Mass Communications from Liberty University, Lynchburg Virginia. She has written several novels, The Eyes of Aisha, Red Diary and Tulips for Sarah.

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